

# Media Patronage: Selection and Survival to Shape Foreign Media

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## Abstract

Authoritarian regimes often seek to influence media beyond their borders, but applying transnational repression can be politically and economically costly. We argue that the financial strain facing media organizations worldwide has created a low-cost alternative: “media patronage,” the selective support of outlets whose coverage already slants toward the regime. Media patronage does not seek to change individual journalists or outlets but operates at the ecosystem level, increasing the share of pro-regime media over time. We document the Chinese Communist Party’s use of this strategy in global Chinese-language digital news, analyzing 14 million articles from 193 outlets over 25 years. We find that outlets with more positive coverage of China and less coverage of censored topics are selected for patronage, and outlet slant remains unchanged after selection. Patronage helps outlets survive, increasing web traffic by 27% and reducing the likelihood of closure by 57% relative to unaffiliated peers. Finally, we show overseas patronage has domestic payoffs: during China’s 2022 Zero-COVID protests, the absence of protest coverage from patronage outlets meant protest narratives did not dominate the flow of diaspora media back into China’s domestic information environment. These results contribute to research on transnational repression, political influence on media, and authoritarian politics.

**Keywords:** Media capture, information manipulation, transnational repression, authoritarian influence, China, diaspora

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Authoritarian regimes often seek to influence media production outside their borders. These efforts have varied aims—e.g., to discredit opponents, stop transnational movements, bolster domestic propaganda, or influence foreign elites and publics (Huang 2015; Huang and Yeh 2019; Kern and Hainmueller 2009; Kern 2011; Nugent and Siegel 2026; Peisakhin and Rozenas 2018; Repnikova 2022)—but are hampered by territorial boundaries. Inside their borders, autocrats have numerous institutional tools from regulatory agencies to the police to control media (Lucas 2022; McMillan and Zoido 2004; Rahmani 2025; Rosenfeld and Wallace 2024; Stockmann and Gallagher 2011). Outside state borders, foreign sovereignty and geographic distance can hinder attempts at control.

Existing research has focused on how authoritarian regimes can influence foreign media outlets with transnational repression. These strategies range from exploiting international legal institutions like Interpol to arrest journalists, to digital harassment, to applying relational pressure such as the detention of family members who remain in-country (Deng and O'Brien 2013; Dukalskis et al. 2022; Earl, Maher and Pan 2022; Hassan, Mattingly and Nugent 2022; Moss 2016; Tsourapas 2021). Research has also shown how authoritarian regimes try to influence foreign information environments by directly founding and operating state-controlled media organizations abroad (Cull 2009; Fan, Pan and Sheng 2023; Kao 2026). These strategies, while demonstrably effective in many contexts, carry substantial political and financial costs.

In this paper, we argue that *media patronage* is an alternative strategy for authoritarian regimes seeking to influence foreign media—one that is facilitated by the financial strain faced by media organizations worldwide. The advent of the internet and the shift to online advertising has decimated news media revenues, leading to reductions in staffing, declining coverage diversity, and the closure of thousands of news organizations around the world (Crain 2009; Nielsen 2015; Willnat and Martin 2020). In democracies and lower capacity states, where media organizations have historically relied on market revenues rather than domestic government funding (Hamilton 2004), there is increasing evidence that media or-

ganizations under financial strain are susceptible to influence by political interests (Besley and Prat 2006; Tella and Franceschelli 2011).

Media patronage is the selective provision of support to outlets whose coverage already slants toward the patron while shunning critical ones. Patronage does not change the editorial slant of patronized outlets. Instead, patronage funnels financial support to allied outlets, which increases the likelihood they survive. This selective support transforms the media ecosystem as a whole (Weber and Monge 2017). Because friendly outlets disproportionately survive, patronage shifts the composition of media over time, expanding the aggregate supply of pro-patron coverage without altering any single outlet’s editorial line. This strategy, which can be pursued alongside the strengthening of state-run broadcasters that cover global or national affairs as well as targeted repression, helps to fill the void left by the decline in local journalism while advancing the strategic agendas of authoritarian regimes.

We find empirical evidence of media patronage in the case of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and global Chinese-language digital news. By analyzing 14 million articles produced by 193 Chinese-language digital news outlets outside of mainland China as well as a census of all Chinese-language news outlets in the United States over a 25 year period, we find that the CCP is selectively supporting news outlets with a pre-existing slant toward China. After securing CCP support, these organizations do not change their overall pro-China slant. Rather, they gain audience share (27% greater web traffic) and experience a 57% reduction in the likelihood of closure relative to unaffiliated peers. Over time, these changes alter the aggregate supply of pro-China coverage globally.

Finally, we find that the regime’s investment in overseas outlets has domestic payoffs during unforeseen crises. During China’s Zero-COVID (“White Paper”) protests in late 2022, unaffiliated outlets devoted the majority of their Covid coverage to social unrest, while patronage outlets covered it at less than half the rate. Because content from patronage outlets was much more likely to circulate within China than content from unaffiliated outlets, domestic audiences encountered a version of overseas Chinese-language Covid reporting where

protests were peripheral even though social discontent was featured prominently in actual coverage of Covid in Chinese diaspora media.

This research has implications for the study of transnational repression, media markets, and authoritarian politics. On transnational repression, existing work has focused primarily on highly visible coercive tactics such as harassment, detention, and violence (Dukalskis et al. 2022; Moss 2016). This emphasis is driven in part by policy visibility and the attendant data availability: violent, repressive tactics draw attention, documentation, and coverage, increasing the urgency of academic research as well as facilitating its pursuit. Media patronage, by contrast, operates through business transactions that are often legal and routine. These transactions attract less scrutiny than assassinations or kidnappings, yet can nonetheless reshape information environments. Recognizing media patronage as a form of transnational influence—alongside overtly repressive tactics—offers a more complete picture of how authoritarian power operates beyond their borders (Earl, Maher and Pan 2022; Tsourapas 2015).

These results also contribute to a growing body of research on political influence on news media (Alonso and Padró i Miquel 2025; Besley and Prat 2006). Research on media in democracies has historically found market competition to facilitate media independence by providing media organizations with sources of revenue independent of domestic and foreign political actors (Gentzkow, Glaeser and Goldin 2006; Gentzkow and Shapiro 2008; Petrova 2011). Research on media in authoritarian and hybrid regimes shows how autocrats diminish media independence by undermining media competition, e.g., through state ownership, financial sanctions, or proxy influence (Egorov, Guriev and Sonin 2009; Guriev and Treisman 2019; McMillan and Zoido 2004; Pan 2017; Qin, Strömberg and Wu 2018; Rahmani 2025; Shirk 2010; Stockmann and Gallagher 2011). However, recent work challenges this distinction, showing how political influence can operate through the mechanisms of commercial news production, such as advertising and ownership, even in competitive markets (Alonso and Padró i Miquel 2025; Archer and Torres 2022; Grossman, Margalit and Mitts 2022). We

contribute to this line of research by showing that well-resourced actors, including foreign governments, can exploit the financial vulnerability of media organizations to reshape media ecosystems in their favor.

Lastly, this paper has implications for research on authoritarian politics. First, these results are consistent with work showing how authoritarian regimes use propaganda to reinforce existing pro-regime sentiments (Shirikov 2024). As opponents disappear and supporters survive, authoritarian regimes can reshape the information environment without targeting individual changes in expression. Second, this extends the literature on how modern authoritarian regimes sustain power through media manipulation rather than overt repression (Guriev and Treisman 2019; Levitsky and Way 2010; Pan, Xu and Xu 2023) by showing that the informational strategies of modern authoritarianism are not confined to domestic information environments. Third, our finding that overseas media patronage can limit the reach of damaging foreign coverage of domestic crises among home audiences shows that transnational efforts of autocracies serve not only foreign policy goals but domestic political ones as well.

The paper proceeds as follows. In Section 1 we introduce the concept of media patronage. Section 2 describes our case of China and Chinese diasporic media organizations. Section 3 introduces the data and how we identify media patronage. The three subsequent sections present the results: Section 4 shows how outlets are selected for patronage and changes to editorial slant; Section 5 focuses on patronage, survival and ecosystem-level changes; and Section 6 examines the implications of media patronage for information control within China’s domestic information environment. Section 7 concludes.

## 1. Media Patronage

The concept of media patronage adapts the logic of patron-client relationships, a form of mutually beneficial arrangement where a patron supports, but does not directly control, clients operating autonomously in pursuit of shared interests (Scott 1972). Patron-client

relationships are a pervasive feature of authoritarian politics and backsliding democracies, where those in power use selective resource allocation to build loyalty among local officials, business elites, and other important actors (Manion 2023; Shih 2007). Despite entering into a relationship of obligation with the patron, clients retain autonomy, and maintain the relationship primarily due to common interests rather than the continuous threat of coercion. As a consequence, the patron benefits not by directing the client’s behavior but by sustaining a client whose independent activity advances interests they share (Kitschelt, Wilkinson et al. 2007; Munro 2010).

The presence of common interests means that unlike strategies that seek to alter media behavior at the individual level via coercion or co-optation, media patronage operates through the strategic selection of willing partners.<sup>1</sup> Media coverage is publicly observable, so patrons can identify candidate outlets by inferring its editorial orientation from existing reporting and thereafter direct resources to them.<sup>2</sup> Patronage sustains already supportive outlets to participate in an ongoing arena of political competition rather than trying to change critical ones (Nichter 2008).

Media patronage is sustained by business transactions, whether direct transfers of resources or intermediate forms such as advertising purchases, content licensing, and content sharing. What makes these transactions patronage is not their form but their selective allocation to outlets based on prior alignment rather than commercial criteria. These transactions do not transfer editorial control to the patron. Indeed, client autonomy is an important part of what makes media patronage effective. The client’s value to the patron is tied to its sensitivity to local conditions and credibility with local audiences, which state-controlled media lacks. If a patronized outlet visibly alters its editorial line, it may lose local trust as

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<sup>1</sup>Some studies use “co-optation” broadly to include what we call patronage (e.g., Kao 2026; Tsourapas 2021). We use the term patronage to draw an analytical distinction. While both patronage and co-optation entail the provision of benefits, the difference lies in *who* it is provided to rather than *what* is provided. Co-optation supplies benefits to opponents or potential opponents in order to induce behavior change, while patronage selects allies whose behavior already aligns with patron interests. This distinction matters because they are associated with different behavioral outcomes—co-optation necessitates editorial change while patronage does not.

<sup>2</sup>Selecting organizations with common interests also diminishes the need for client monitoring—a result known as the “ally principle” (Bendor, Glazer and Hammond 2000).

it becomes indistinguishable from state-controlled media. If a patronized outlet must solicit regime approval before each coverage decision, it cannot produce news with the alacrity sufficient to meet audience information needs and compete for attention. Altogether, editorial control by the patron is not only unnecessary because clients are selected for prior alignment, but may reduce the very qualities that make clients valuable to the patron in the first place.

Over time, patronage thus secures changes in the overall market without editorial changes at each outlet. The transfer of resources gives patronage outlets a financial advantage over unaffiliated outlets who do not receive comparable support. Where media outlets face financial pressures, as in today's media landscape, this advantage reduces the likelihood that patronage outlets exit relative to unaffiliated peers. Because patronage outlets survive at a higher rate, patronage changes the composition of the media market through attrition. The result is a politically favorable media environment for the patron, increasingly composed of aligned outlets.

Patronage offers several advantages over alternative strategies. First, it carries lower political risk than repression. Transnational repression of media professionals can backfire when discovered. The murder of *Washington Post* columnist Jamal Khashoggi caused many foreign firms to reconsider investing in Saudi Arabia and generated substantial negative press for the Kingdom (McPherson-Smith 2021). The extraterritorial kidnapping of Hong Kong booksellers generated international condemnation and diplomatic tensions (Ramzy 2020). Although media patronage may over time acquire coercive dimensions as financial dependence deepens, this coercion is not as overt as in direct repression and is thus far less visible.

Second, media patronage may be more efficient than co-optation, which targets threats or potential threats and seeks to neutralize them. The relationship between patron and client is hierarchical and aligned, while the relationship between co-opter and co-opted is potentially adversarial. Inducing an opposed actor to cease opposition—and monitoring their ongoing compliance—requires more resources and carries greater risk of failure than

sustaining a client who was never opposed to begin with (Eisenstadt and Roniger 1984; Scott 1972).<sup>3</sup> Co-optation of hostile outlets may also generate backlash, as dramatic changes in editorial stance cause formerly independent organization to lose credibility or as displaced media professionals create new dissident outlets (Ebsworth 2017; Kao 2026).

Third, the commercial transactions underlying media patronage provide plausible deniability that direct state ownership does not. State broadcasters like RT and CGTN can be labeled as foreign agents, leading to government registration, platform labeling, and audiences to potentially discount their credibility (Mena 2020; Nassetta and Gross 2020). Covert state-controlled outlets, when exposed, suffer catastrophic loss in credibility (Cohen 2015; Fittarelli 2024). With media patronage, client outlets retain editorial autonomy and continue to make independent decisions, particularly on matters outside of the patron’s core interests. This makes state sponsorship easy to deny. When media organizations decline patron support, they typically do so out of professional integrity and the desire to avoid real or perceived conflicts of interest rather than because the transactions themselves are illegal (of Professional Journalists 2014). The need to avoid even the perception of bias means that the patronage relationship is binary—it is the acceptance of resources from a political patron, rather than the magnitude of resources that constitutes the relationship. When patronage resources are accepted, client outlets are no longer fully independent, as they depend on maintaining a relationship with a political sponsor, but neither are they directly state-controlled (Bodrunova, Litvinenko and Nigmatullina 2021; Repnikova 2018; Stockmann and Gallagher 2011).<sup>4</sup>

One aspect of media patronage we take as true by assumption is the financial vulnerability of media outlets: we assume all non-government supported outlets are financially vulnerable. Our theory of media patronage generates the following observable implications.

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<sup>3</sup>For more on the oppositional character of co-optation, see (Gandhi and Przeworski 2006).

<sup>4</sup>In some ways patronage outlets resemble the intermediate status of semi-independent outlets within authoritarian borders. Hong Kong media outlets in the wake of the territory’s 1997 handover to the PRC offer an illustrative comparison. The PRC during that time allowed the territory substantial autonomy, but the outlets nevertheless navigated implicit restrictions on reporting as the threat of PRC intervention loomed large, see (Lee and Lin 2006).

First, clients should be **selected** for patronage on the basis of their pro-regime editorial inclination. After patronage, these organizations’ overall stance toward the patron should **not change**. Second, patronage should help client outlets **survive** amid declining worldwide media revenues, especially compared to outlets which do not accept patronage support. Over time, this selective support should reshape the market for news as pro-regime outlets persist while unaffiliated outlets do not, advancing the regime’s strategic objectives.

Media patronage depends on several scope conditions. First, it requires the presence of media organizations under financial strain. In contexts with robust media revenue or extensive domestic subsidies, the opportunities for patrons diminish. Second, media patronage requires heterogeneity in the media landscape such that potential allies exist for selection. In highly consolidated or homogeneous media environments, patrons may face difficulty finding suitable clients (in hostile environments) or have minimal incentives to conduct patronage as coverage is already positive (in supportive environments). Third, it requires a patronage actor willing to deploy resources to support media in competitive media markets. In theory, any well-resourced political actor can engage in media patronage, and some democracies have done so, such as when the U.S. subsidized anti-Communist journals during the Cold War (Saunders 2000).<sup>5</sup> In practice, however, authoritarian regimes are more willing and better positioned to do so. Authoritarian regimes, especially those with strong domestic information controls, are less likely to face domestic constraints on selectively supporting aligned foreign media and have the institutional capacity for identifying and cultivating potential clients. They also often have strong strategic interests in shaping external information environments, where foreign media coverage can filter back to domestic audiences or influence transnational opposition movements. Lastly, the regulatory environment of the target market must permit foreign funding of media organizations without intense scrutiny such that patronage can operate as routine commercial activity. If foreign investment in domestic media is heavily monitored or restricted, patronage becomes riskier and less attractive compared

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<sup>5</sup>More generally, democracies do fund foreign media through development assistance, but such programs claim to allocate resources based on journalistic quality or institutional capacity rather than content alignment, which would not constitute media patronage.

with alternatives.

## 2. China and its Diaspora

We turn to China and Chinese-language diasporic media worldwide to evaluate our argument because this case meets the scope conditions for media patronage.

First, Chinese diasporic media are financially vulnerable. They serve relatively small populations—Chinese diasporas are typically an ethnic and linguistic minority within the larger host society—which constrains both their advertising revenue and subscription base. Chinese diasporic media also face stiff competitive pressure from two directions: they compete for audience attention with both mainstream host country media and with Chinese mainland media increasingly accessible via digital platforms.

Second, Chinese diasporic media contains a wide distribution of media slants both for and against the PRC, allowing us to test a theory of media selection. Some diasporic Chinese media outlets, such as those founded by practitioners of Falun Gong, a religious movement banned in China since 1999, are opponents of the Communist Party (Ownby 2008). Other Chinese media outlets are commercially-minded, seeking to turn a profit from informational needs of Chinese immigrant populations. Yet others with business ties to the Chinese mainland operate media organizations with a pro-regime slant. This diverse population presents a wide variety of media biases.

Finally, the Chinese Communist Party has a strategic interest in influencing diasporic Chinese media. China’s overseas migrant population surpassed 8.6 million in 2024 (see Figure 1), with particularly large concentrations in established democracies (US 2.5 million, Japan 810,000) (United Nations, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division 2024).<sup>6</sup> This population continues to consume media in Chinese: according to

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<sup>6</sup>The U.N. defines “migrant” as individuals living for more than 12 months outside their country of birth or citizenship. When birth data is available, it is preferred to citizenship when calculating the statistics, see United Nations, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division (2024). The U.N.’s migrant population data is an imperfect proxy for Chinese news consumers for several reasons. First, some migrants may consume information in the host country language (e.g. a Chinese migrant in the U.S. consuming English-language news), leading this proxy to overestimate the Chinese news consuming

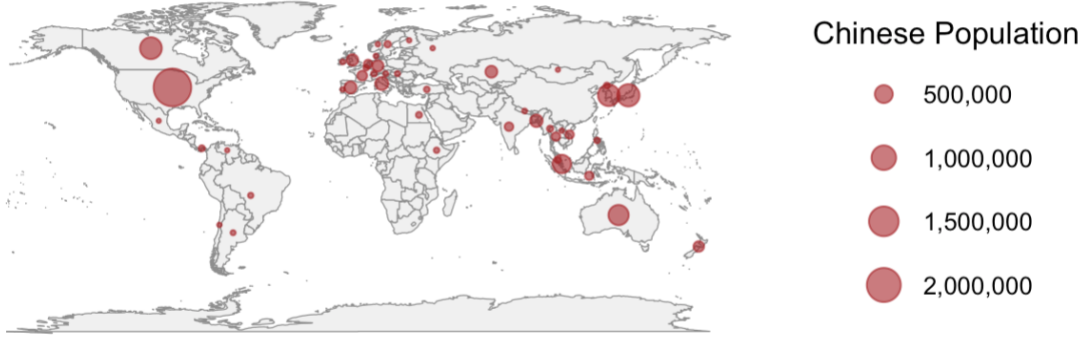


FIGURE 1. CHINESE MIGRANT POPULATION, 2024.

the National Asian American Survey, 66.3% of Chinese respondents read news in Chinese in 2008 (the last year in which the question was asked), with 41.0% preferring Chinese-language sources.<sup>7</sup>

Overseas Chinese have historically contributed to political movements on the mainland—from Sun Yat-Sen’s Nationalist fundraising among Hawaiian Chinese in the early 20th century to reform-era returnees contributing skills to China’s economic development in the post-Mao years. Chinese-American newspapers have been politically connected for generations: writing in the 1980s, [Lai \(1987\)](#) noted that Chinese-language media outlets often took advantage of America’s comparative media freedom to advocate for Chinese political parties. More recently, overseas Chinese operating outside the Great Firewall have served as information conduits during political crises, such as the 2022 White Paper protests, sharing censored content to domestic audiences involved in the protests ([Chang et al. 2022](#); [Economist 2022](#)). Diasporic media organizations thus represent both an opportunity to cultivate favorable narratives among a strategically important population and a threat through which opposition movements can reach domestic audiences.

Beyond meeting scope conditions, focusing on the relationship between the CCP and

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population. On the other hand, some native-born speakers—who are not migrants and thus excluded from the U.N. count—may consume Chinese-language news alongside news in the host country language (e.g. a second-generation Chinese-Peruvian consuming Chinese-language news). This possibility would lead the U.N. estimate to undercount the Chinese news consuming population. In the Appendix, we also provide two other estimates for diasporic Chinese news consumers: unique website visits to Chinese websites and downloads of Chinese-language apps (see Appendix [A1.4](#)).

<sup>7</sup>The survey uses self-identification to determine Chinese identity.

Chinese-language diasporic media allows us to assess whether media patronage complements previously identified strategies. This is because the Chinese government can and often does target its own diasporic media producers with transnational repression and co-optation. In southeast Asia, the PRC has orchestrated the kidnapping of ethnic Chinese booksellers, including one with foreign nationality; in Australia, it has targeted ethnic Chinese journalists with coordinated campaigns of harassment (Hsiao-hwa 2024; Ramzy 2020). China has the willingness and capacity to practice transnational repression to influence foreign media when it chooses to. Does it also take advantage of the financial vulnerabilities of these news outlets through media patronage?

PRC policy documents confirm that resource provision to diasporic media outlets serves a strategic political interest. These documents mention two interrelated goals. One goal is to cultivate affective ties among overseas Chinese and foreign nationals of ethnic Chinese descent to promote the CCP’s political agenda, including support during political crises or geopolitical conflict (Chinese Radio Seattle 2023; World Chinese Media 2001). President Xi Jinping emphasized this goal by evoking the Maoist phrase “unite all that can be united” (团结一切可以团结的力量) at the 2015 United Front Work Conference (Xi 2015). Another goal is to use diasporic Chinese-language media as a channel to “transmit China’s voice” globally and strengthen China’s “international right to speak” (CNS 2012; OCAO 2007).<sup>8</sup> While the first goal is focused on diaspora populations, the second also has implications for domestic audiences, given the importance of foreign sources during domestic crises (Chang et al. 2022; Chen and Yang 2019; Hanley, Lu and Pan 2025).

The Chinese regime pursues these goals through a centralized coordinating body, the Overseas Chinese Affairs Office (OCAO, 国务院侨务办公室), which was previously in the State Council (the PRC’s highest government organ) but has since been subsumed into the Party’s United Front Work Department (a Party organ dedicated to managing relations with non-Party actors). OCAO is explicitly tasked with influencing ethnic Chinese of foreign na-

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<sup>8</sup>These objectives are consistent with a general shift toward using diasporic media, and diasporic populations more generally, as “public diplomats” on behalf of PRC strategic objectives (Thunø 2017).

tionality. Beginning in 2001, OCAO and the China News Service (CNS) (中国新闻社), a Chinese-language global news agency dedicated to producing “news and information for [...] overseas Chinese and Chinese with foreign nationalities,”<sup>9</sup> jointly launched the World Chinese Media Forum, a recurring summit that has convened hundreds of overseas Chinese media executives in China for sessions ranging from political orientation to content-sharing agreements to the construction of shared digital infrastructure (World Chinese Media 2001; Chinese Radio Seattle 2023), as well as other training programs. The integration of the OCAO into the United Front was part of a broader effort to institutionalize Party control of efforts related to overseas Chinese affairs. This structure, which includes dedicated bureaucracies and recurring coordinating forums and training programs, means that if media patronage occurs, it reflects a sustained top-down effort led by the CCP through the United Front, the OCAO, and the CNS.

Interviews with current and former representatives of Chinese-language diasporic media organizations confirm that PRC resource provision operates as our theory predicts (for more information on interviews, see Appendix A1.5). Organization F, located in a major Latin-American city, described being approached by a representative from the People’s Daily overseas edition: “In 2014, they [the representative] came by on a visit and saw our paper copy, which we had at the time, and saw that our position and point-of-view was proper so they invited us to partner with them” (2014年, 有《人民日报海外版》的人来访, 看了我们当时的纸质杂志, 也了解了我们的发行情况, 觉得我们的观点和立场都比较正面、比较对路, 所以后来就邀请我们合作).<sup>10</sup> Organization H notes that their “most substantive media collaboration is with China News Agency [...] from which [we] subscribe to news and photo services. Content provided through these channels is disseminated selectively on [our] news portal, subject to editorial judgment and relevance to our readership.”

PRC patronage takes multiple forms. The previous example concerned content sharing of

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<sup>9</sup>The CNS has been described by foreign observers as the CCP’s “main propaganda organ targeting overseas Chinese, <https://jamestown.org/program/how-the-ccp-mobilized-a-cross-border-disinformation-campaign-against-the-czech-senate-speaker/>. See also <https://www.chinanews.com.cn/common/footer/aboutus.shtml>.

<sup>10</sup>Interview with Organization F.

content from PRC outlets with diaspora media. Other forms include facilitating the reshare of diaspora media content with domestic China audiences, which in turn boosts advertising revenue for the diaspora outlet. For example, a representative of Organization I, located in a small European country, described PRC article re-shares as key to generating traffic, noting that because the Chinese-speaking readership of their country was minimal—no more than 10,000—if an article has 40,000 viewers it must have views from mainland China: “Some [government] WeChat accounts will promote us and re-share our articles [...] good articles have to rely on Chinese audiences to generate real traffic” (有一些微信公众号会推广，会自动转发…好的文章要靠中国的读者上去，在这里是上不去的).<sup>11</sup> Moreover, accepting or rejecting PRC resources is seen as a binary status: Organization H described getting social media contact requests from a representative from a PRC Propaganda Department (a potential precursor to patronage ties), but declined because “they’re very bureaucratic, and if you work with them you sometimes get pressure [...] we reduced costs to avoid that pressure.”<sup>12</sup>

### 3. Data

To evaluate our argument, we create two new datasets: a global dataset of 193 Chinese-language digital news organizations outside mainland China, Taiwan, and Hong Kong/Macau, and a historical census of 221 Chinese-language news organizations in the United States from 2000 to 2025. We describe each in turn before detailing how we operationalize media patronage across both.

#### 3.1. Global Chinese-Language Digital News Dataset

To assess whether the PRC is conducting media patronage abroad, we construct a novel dataset of Chinese-language digital news organizations outside of mainland China, Taiwan, and Hong Kong/Macau, which we refer to as the *Global Dataset*. We operationalize “digital

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<sup>11</sup>Interview with Organization I.

<sup>12</sup>Interview with Organization H, conducted in English.

news organization” as any *online entity* which (1) maintains an independent web domain hosting news content consistently accessible from U.S.-based web browsers as of June 2024,<sup>13</sup> and (2) features human creation or curation of news content.<sup>14</sup> We further require that the organization (3) is not explicitly disclosed as owned or operated by a sovereign government;<sup>15</sup> (4) covers general interest news rather than a single topic (e.g., the oil industry); and (5) is not a duplicate of content syndicated under another domain already in the dataset.<sup>16</sup>

We adopt these criteria for the following reasons. We require an independent web domain because domains proxy for a minimal level of organization capacity—the purchase, design, and upkeep of a domain name requires greater organizational capacity than opening a social media channel—and provide a more stable unit for cross-sectional analysis than social media accounts, which can vary across platforms, regions, and over time. Social media content also introduces platform-based variance both in format (e.g., character limits or unique symbols), and also, crucially, in degree of censorship. Chinese-language news production on social media frequently occurs on Chinese domestic apps such as WeChat or Weibo, which means that all news content, including content produced abroad, is already subject to platform-based censorship implemented on behalf of the CCP. Since we are interested in authoritarian influence on overseas news production, studying content on domestic Chinese platforms would mean that all units are already “treated” due to compliance with domestic Chinese regulations. We exclude sovereign government-owned outlets because our interest is in whether authoritarian regimes can influence ostensibly independent news organizations.

Identifying the global population of Chinese-language news organizations, many of whom serve small diasporic communities, is a substantial challenge. We employed five overlapping

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<sup>13</sup>Four organizations were not consistently accessible but otherwise met the study criteria.

<sup>14</sup>This definition therefore excludes social media accounts or video channels which do not possess their own domain name, as is the case with many Chinese-language “self media” (*zimeiti*) accounts, often operated by an individual or small team of individuals. It includes outlets which primarily translate or curate news while producing minimal content themselves.

<sup>15</sup>This excludes outlets such as the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC), Russia Today (RT), and the China Global Television Network (CGTN). If a website states that it is operated from both mainland China and abroad, it is excluded. If a website does not state from where it is operated, it is included.

<sup>16</sup>For example, *Sinchew Daily* (星洲网) is a Malaysia-based Chinese-language newspaper which operates in Indonesia under a different masthead. Its Indonesian version is considered a duplicate and is not included in the analysis.

approaches to construct this study population. The first approach used web traffic. We acquired a list of the top million global web domains ranked by website traffic from the network analysis firm, Cloudflare. We then subset to all domains labeled as “news” by Cloudflare, and further subset to all websites written in simplified or traditional Chinese.<sup>17</sup> The second approach entailed a breadth-based search of one of the most popular diasporic websites, *Literature City* (文学城), identifying all news organizations it linked to between 2019-2021. We then located as many news domains as possible associated with these news organizations. In the third approach, we identified all diasporic news organizations indexed by WiseNews, a popular database of Chinese-language news content. Fourth, we contacted an *NPR* reporter, Emily Feng, the author of a 2018 *Financial Times* investigation into PRC influence abroad,<sup>18</sup> who graciously shared her database of news organizations with us. The fifth approach involved looking up each news website on SimilarWeb, a web data analytics company, to identify additional websites which attract similar users and web traffic patterns to the news organizations we had already identified, and recursively repeating this process until we did not identify any further organizations.<sup>19</sup> After collecting these domains we manually checked each organization to ensure it met our criteria for news production. We identified 193 Chinese-language digital news organizations with this data collection process.<sup>20</sup> Despite serving limited audiences, these sites remain quite popular: in 2024, they had a median of 3,726 monthly visitors (mean = 463,747, based on 183 of 193 outlets).<sup>21</sup>

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<sup>17</sup>We used the Python library *langdetect* to identify the website’s language.

<sup>18</sup>See <https://www.ft.com/content/f5d00a86-3296-11e8-b5bf-23cb17fd1498>.

<sup>19</sup>We refrain from providing the names of individual outlets to minimize risks of reputational, commercial, or regulatory harm.

<sup>20</sup>In this process, we also identified 46 news organizations based in Hong Kong, Macau, and Taiwan; we use these outlets for an exploratory analysis of the effect of physical repression in the case of Hong Kong and dissident newspapers, see Appendix A3.1.

<sup>21</sup>For robustness, we also gathered these numbers from alternate data provider in the month of June 2024, SimilarWeb.com, and find them broadly comparable (176/193 outlets, *median* = 13,200, *mean* = 516,464).

### 3.2. US Chinese-Language News Census Dataset

Because we are interested in measuring survival at the media market level, we construct a second, new dataset that represents a historical census of both print and digital news outlets operating in the U.S. market since 2000, which we refer to as the *US Census Dataset*.<sup>22</sup>

Unlike the Global Dataset where we identified outlets at the time of study and collected data going back in time, for this historical US news organization census, we began with historical sources and collected forward in time. Through extensive searches of archival and digital sources, we identified 221 outlets active in the United States anytime between 2000 and 2025, of which 93 were active through the start of our study period.

Our inclusion criteria for U.S. news organizations is broader than for global digital news organizations as disambiguating Chinese-language historical newspapers, many of which share the same English or Chinese names, was a formidable challenge, and many outlets have no website or produce only scanned versions of a print newspaper. Because we could not reliably determine whether a defunct outlet was based in the United States or merely stationed foreign correspondents there, we included any organization which archival sources mentioned as having a U.S. presence. We also assumed that an outlet covered general interest news unless their organization name explicitly named a specialty news interest (e.g. “New York Art Weekly”). For more information on how we assembled this historical dataset, including overlap to the Global Dataset, see Appendix A1.2.

### 3.3. Operationalizing Patronage

We conceptualize patronage as a binary condition: having accepted a linkage to the CCP that has direct or indirect impacts for outlet revenue. We rely on three sources to identify whether a news organization in either the Global Dataset or US Census Dataset formed these linkages. If any of the three sources reveal that an outlet has a CCP linkage, we designate

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<sup>22</sup>We gather metadata on their existence over time, recording as their end date the date of their last published story or the reported closure of their newspaper, whichever is later. Where digital versions of newspapers are not available, we use the date of last archived print copy.

that outlet as linked via media patronage.

Our first source is investigative reporting. Specifically, we turn to the underlying data for *FT*’s 2018 investigative story into PRC content-sharing agreements, and record the year in which each content agreement was signed. After manually reviewing all content-sharing announcements, we identify 67 diasporic outlets in our dataset which have entered into partnerships with PRC organizations.

Our second source is the Chinese Communist Party, and in particular an organization called the Global Chinese Media Cooperative Union (GCMCU) (*Shijie Huawen Meiti Hezuo Lianmeng*), operated by the CNS within the Party’s United Front Work Department. The GCMCU publishes a list of all news organizations collaborating with the CCP, alongside the date that an agreement was announced. Using this method, we identify 112 news organizations partnering with the Chinese government, of which 57 also appear as government-linked via investigative reporting based on the first source.

Our final source is a “Internet Content Provider” (ICP) permit on the diaspora news organization domain pages. Here we exploit a feature of Chinese internet regulation: according to Chinese law, all China-based webpages must obtain an ICP permit from the Chinese Ministry of Industry and Information Technology. This ICP number indicates that the website is being operated in accordance with PRC regulations, including speech restrictions. This ICP number facilitates access to domestic Chinese audiences and the attendant advertising revenue, but comes at the cost of the website’s editorial independence by exposing it to legal liability. It indicates that the outlet accepts access to the Chinese market conditional upon circumscribed editorial decisions. On many webpages, the ICP number is displayed in small font at the website’s footer. By sifting through all websites homepages archived by the Wayback Machine, we can identify the first time that an ICP number appears on a news organization’s homepage (see sample footer Figure 2). We then mark that date as the date of first affiliation. Using this method, we identify 55 news organizations as government-linked, of which 27 are also identified via the other two approaches above.<sup>23</sup>

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<sup>23</sup>Once affiliated, outlets do not appear to renege; of the 29 outlets revealed as linked in the 2018 *FT* reporting



FIGURE 2. WEBPAGE FOOTER WITH ICP NUMBER.

The provision of patron resources is sometimes unobservable—direct cash transfers, for instance, leave no public trace—making a full accounting of the patronage relationship impossible. Any operationalization based on visible markers is therefore likely to undercount patronage’s actual prevalence, as some outlets may have accepted resources through channels we cannot observe. Reassuringly, however, this undercounting biases our study against finding differences between patronage and unaffiliated outlets, as patronage outlets incorrectly classified as unaffiliated would diminish the observed differences between the two groups in selection and survival.

## 4. Patronage as Selection

The first observable implication of media patronage is that outlets should be selected for patronage on the basis of the pre-existing slant of their reporting. After selection, their reporting should not change.

To evaluate this, we gather all published articles from news organizations in the Global Dataset, including URL, date, title, and content, appearing on each news domain, reaching as many years back as each news organization’s website permitted us. Data collection began in March 2024 and ended in January 2025. After data cleaning and de-duplication (see prior to 2013 (10 years before our study’s onset), 27 of them remained linked via GCMCU or ICP numbers at the time our data collection began.

Appendix A1.3), our data consisted of 13,990,206 articles spanning over 30 years, with a median of 16,145 articles (and mean of 72,488 articles) per organization. This source of data is rich but high variance, as articles from some news organizations were accessible for over 20 years while others were available only a few years into the past. On average, our dataset consists of 6.8 years of data per outlet (median of 6 years).

We construct two variables to measure whether an outlet’s editorial slant favored China prior to the provision of resources. The first is stance toward China, as “telling China’s story well” is a primary strategic objective of the PRC. We measure an outlet’s stance toward China by using a three-step machine-assisted labeling process with human validation. First, we determined each outlet’s percent of China coverage by asking human coders to label a 1,600-article sample (stratified by outlet and year) as related to China (intercoder agreement = 95.2%), and use that sample to fine-tune a supervised learning model (DeBERTa) to replicate those labels on our full dataset ( $F1=0.91$ ).<sup>24</sup> Second, we asked human coders to assess the stance toward China of each China-related article ( $n = 654$ , intercoder agreement = 81.8%), with 1 representing “positive” and 0 representing “neutral or negative.” Finally, we used GPT-4o to replicate those labels on China-labeled articles from Step 1.<sup>25</sup> For cost reasons, we sampled 10% of articles of outlets with >10,000 articles. For more details on coding rules, see Appendix A2.1, and for the generation of stance classifications, see Appendix A2.2. Our final labels contain three sources of error: DeBERTa’s misclassification of China relevance, GPT’s misclassification of stance, and sampling error for the 62 outlets from which we analyzed only 10% of articles. We treat DeBERTa’s China-relevance classifications as defining our analysis sample and do not propagate this uncertainty. We propagate the latter two sources using a non-parametric bootstrap (1,000 iterations) that randomly flips GPT labels at the estimated classifier error rate and re-samples from partially sampled outlets, constructing confidence intervals from the resulting distribution of values (see Error Propagation in Appendix A2.4 for details).

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<sup>24</sup><https://huggingface.co/IDEA-CCNL/Erlangshen-DeBERTa-v2-320M-Chinese>

<sup>25</sup>GPT-4o-mini-2024-07-18

The second variable of editorial slant is censored topic coverage. We select four topics related to territorial separatism and accusations of Party wrongdoing that are considered potential “focal points” for protests (Stern and Hassid 2012; Truex 2019): Falun Gong, the Tiananmen Square massacre, the Dalai Lama, and Xinjiang concentration camps. In China, any mention of these topics by private or semi-private media outlets is forbidden; only “white-listed” (Party-owned) outlets are permitted to discuss them, and they seldom do so (Fu, Chan and Chau 2013; Yin, Fu and Zheng 2024). As a result, these topics are rarely discussed at all.<sup>26</sup> We check for the presence of any word related to these four events by compiling a list of related words for each event and averaging the total number of articles mentioning each of these keywords (see Appendix A2.5 for a full list of keywords). An outlet’s coverage rate of these censored topics is the percentage of its stories containing these keywords.

#### 4.1. Selection on Pre-existing Slant

Our results show that Chinese language news outlets selected for patronage are significantly more positive toward China than unaffiliated outlets, and are more likely to avoid mention of censored topics prior to patronage. In Figure 3, each dot represents an outlet, while the larger dot is the annual average of each group: in orange are outlets that will later receive economic resources from the CCP (will be selected for patronage but have not yet been). After an outlet partners with the PRC, they are removed from the figure. In blue are outlets that remain unaffiliated with the PRC during the duration of the study period. Panel A shows that patronized outlets are more positive about China prior to patronization than unaffiliated outlets in all years during the study period. Similarly, Panel B shows that later-patronized outlets rarely—and in many cases never—discuss censored topics, in contrast to unaffiliated outlets’ occasional coverage of these issues. Together these results show that the CCP selectively supports outlets that are already sympathetic to PRC strategic objectives.

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<sup>26</sup>The sensitivity of these terms were also confirmed during our qualitative interviews.

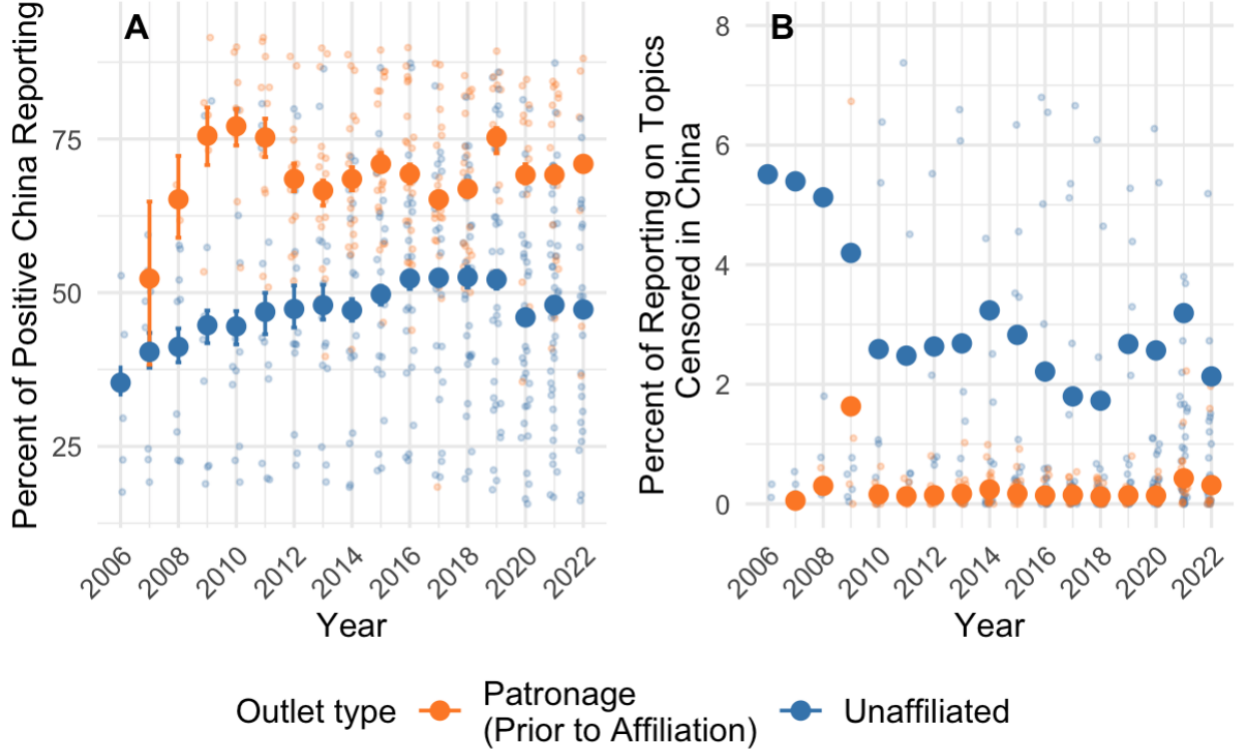


FIGURE 3. SLANT OF COVERAGE OF MEDIA OUTLETS PRIOR TO LINKAGE FORMATION. PANEL A: STANCE TOWARD CHINA. PANEL B: CENSORED TOPIC COVERAGE.

More formally, we also estimate a discrete-time hazard model to assess the likelihood that an outlet’s pre-affiliation news coverage stance toward China predicts its likelihood of affiliating in a given year ( $\beta_1$ ), controlling for outlet and country-level covariates and conditional on not having affiliated previously:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{logit}(h_{it}) = & \alpha_t + \beta_1 \text{Positive\_Coverage}_{it} \\ & + \beta_2 \log(\text{Articles\_Count}_{it}) + \beta_3 \text{FreeExp}_{ct} \\ & + \beta_4 \text{Age}_{it} + \varepsilon_{it} \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

where  $\beta_1$  estimates the association between the percentage of an outlet’s China coverage that is positive toward China and the log-odds of affiliation, and is the primary quantity of interest.  $\beta_2$  is the logged annual article count. Because country fixed effects would absorb too many degrees of freedom, we instead estimate  $\beta_3$  on V-Dem’s freedom-of-expression and alternative-information index, where higher values represent a freer information environment. This measures country-level effects that are associated with media freedom. Outlet age ( $\beta_4$ ),

measures the time at risk since the beginning of our observation window in 2002. Year fixed effects ( $\alpha_t$ ) absorb common temporal shocks to the affiliation rate.

The results in Table 1 show that outlets with more positive China coverage face higher hazards of affiliation ( $\beta_1 = 0.034$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), even after controlling for their host country’s freedom of expression rankings, article count, and time at risk.<sup>27</sup>

TABLE 1. DISCRETE-TIME HAZARD MODEL OF PATRONAGE AFFILIATION

|                       | <i>Dependent variable:</i>    |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------|
|                       | Patronage affiliation         |
| Positive stance (%)   | 0.034***<br>(0.008)           |
| Log article count     | −0.120<br>(0.108)             |
| Freedom of expression | 0.069<br>(0.715)              |
| Outlet age            | 0.012<br>(0.028)              |
| Constant              | −44.044<br>(12503.090)        |
| Year fixed effects    | Yes                           |
| Observations          | 762                           |
| Log Likelihood        | −133.853                      |
| Akaike Inf. Crit.     | 323.705                       |
| <i>Note:</i>          | *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001 |

## 4.2. No Change in Coverage after Patronage

Patronage should work by shifting market share, not changing content. To determine whether patronage changes content, we focus on the 28 outlets for which web-scraping provided at least one full year of full-text data available before and after patronage. For each outlet, we calculate the annual percentage of stories with positive stance toward China and containing censored topics.

<sup>27</sup>Outlets without a host country are dropped due to the lack of V-Dem covariates.

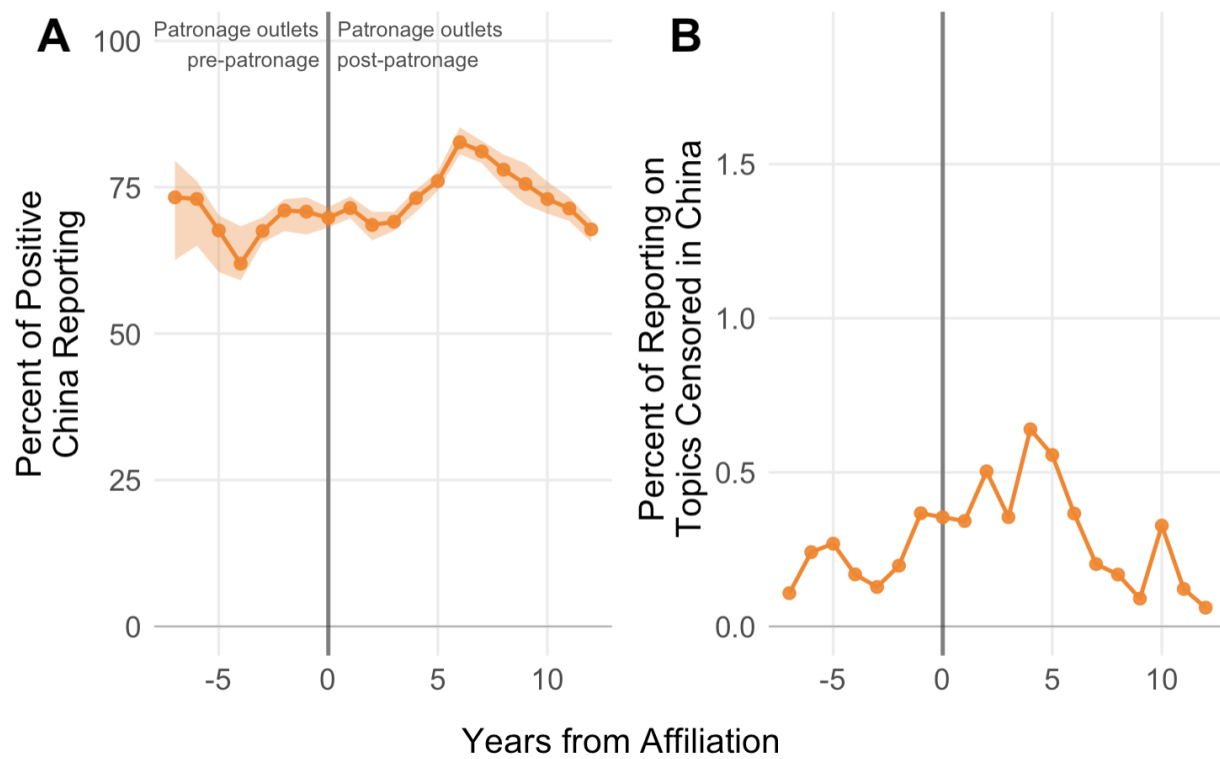


FIGURE 4. SLANT OF COVERAGE OF MEDIA OUTLETS BEFORE AND AFTER PATRONAGE. PANEL A: STANCE TOWARD CHINA. PANEL B: COVERAGE OF TOPICS CENSORED IN CHINA. VERTICAL LINE AT YEAR OF PATRONAGE AFFILIATION.

In alignment with our expectation, Figure 4, Panel A shows that post-patronage (to the right of the vertical grey line marking the year of first affiliation), the stance of patronized outlets remains consistent with coverage prior to patronage, with no increase in positive stance after linkages are established. Panel B shows that mention of censored topics also do not change. We also check whether outlets become more negative toward their host country and find that they do not (see Appendix A3.2).<sup>28</sup> These results show that media patronage seeks to support already friendly outlets rather than transforming critical ones.

## 5. Patronage and Global Markets

The second observable implication of our theory is that patronage helps friendly outlets survive, gradually reshaping the composition of media producers within the market. To assess this argument, we measure: (1) the effect of patronage on web traffic for organizations in the Global Dataset, (2) the direct association between patronage and outlet survival in the US Census Dataset, and (3) whether the overall global market for Chinese-language news is becoming more positive toward China over time.

For digital news websites dependent on viewership and advertising sales, greater traffic numbers mean more advertising income and thus increased revenue necessary for survival. We gather data on estimated historical web traffic data dating to 2017 from Semrush, a web analytics company, retrospectively in February 2026 for outlets in the Global Dataset.<sup>29</sup> Estimated web traffic was available for 187 of 193 news organizations, with 116 outlets available for the full nine year time span, and a mean of 7.6 years available for each website. If an outlet had no recorded traffic in all twelve months of a given year, we recorded that outlet as missing.

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<sup>28</sup>We also measured this variable within a set of Hong Kong-based outlets in the wake of the National Security Law’s implementation in June 2020. This legal change represents direct repression rather than patronage, and in that instance, we do find a sustained rise in post-implementation positivity toward China, see Appendix A3.1. This finding provides reassurance that our variable can capture changes to editorial slant, when present.

<sup>29</sup>Semrush uses anonymous click-stream data from third-party data providers, alongside proprietary modeling, to estimate global web traffic, see <https://www.semrush.com/kb/1211-how-semrush-turns-traffic-data-into-traffic-intelligence>.

Using this historic traffic data, we estimate the effect of patronage on treated outlets' web traffic using generalized synthetic controls (Xu 2017). This method constructs a counterfactual traffic trajectory for each affiliated outlet from a weighted combination of never-affiliated outlets, generalizing the classic synthetic control to settings with multiple treated units and staggered treatment timing. Due to fewer pre-periods and greater granularity in monthly data, we aggregate traffic numbers at each quarter (e.g. Jan-Mar), and restrict the sample to outlets with one full year of pre-affiliation web traffic data ( $n = 32$ ). We allow the estimator to search for up to two latent factors when estimating the following model:

$$Y_{it} = \delta D_{it} + \alpha_i + \xi_t + \lambda'_i f_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (2)$$

where  $Y_{it} = \log(1 + \text{visits}_{it})$  is log-transformed quarterly traffic for outlet  $i$  in quarter  $t$  in a five-year window around the treatment year,  $D_{it}$  is a binary treatment variable set to one beginning the first quarter after PRC affiliation year,  $\alpha_i$  is an outlet fixed effect,  $\xi_t$  is a quarter fixed effect,  $\lambda'_i f_t$  captures unobserved time-varying heterogeneity across outlets, and  $\delta$  is the average treatment effect on the treated (ATT). Note that this specification drops observations from the treatment year because we do not know the exact quarter of affiliation and treatment may take time to take effect.

To assess whether patronage is associated with greater outlet survival, we estimate the protective effect of PRC affiliation with a Cox proportional hazards model on the US Census Dataset. The hazard function for outlet  $i$  at time  $t$  is specified as:

$$h_i(t) = h_0(t) \exp(\beta_1 \text{Affiliated}_{it} + \beta_2 \text{Age}_{it}) \quad (3)$$

where  $h_0(t)$  is an unspecified baseline hazard,  $\text{Affiliated}_{it}$  is a time-varying binary indicator that switches from 0 to 1 in the year outlet  $i$  enters a PRC patronage relationship, and  $\text{Age}_{it}$  is the outlet age in years. Standard errors are clustered at the outlet level to account for within-outlet correlation across periods.

To measure changes in the global Chinese-language media market's stance toward China, we measure the average diasporic media outlet's stance toward China compiled over time.

Note that we only capture outlets who were actively publishing in 2024, when our data collection began, meaning that outlet exits prior to 2024 are omitted from the data. To create this measure, we first take the average percentage of stories that are positive toward China in each outlet-year, and then take the average-of-averages across all outlets active in each year. The result is the global average story positive stance toward China in our dataset in each year.

## 5.1. Patronage Increases Web Traffic

Our analysis shows that patronage boosts web traffic to Chinese-language news organizations. Figure 5 shows the effect of PRC affiliation on affiliated outlets’ logged web traffic.<sup>30</sup> The estimated ATT on logged web traffic across the eight quarters post-affiliation year is 0.235 ( $p = 0.021$ ), equivalent to approximately 27% higher quarterly traffic.<sup>31</sup>

## 5.2. Patronage Aids Survival

Patronage also helps outlets survive longer than their unaffiliated peers. As shown in Table 2, the estimated hazard ratio for affiliated outlets is 0.428,  $p = 0.048$ , indicating that affiliated outlets face approximately 57% lower hazard of closure relative to unaffiliated outlets, after controlling for outlet age. The estimate is imprecise in part because so few affiliated outlets cease operations: of the 26 U.S. outlets active since 2000 that receive patronage, only five have ceased operations (19%), compared to 123 out of 195 unaffiliated outlets during the same time period (63%).<sup>32</sup>

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<sup>30</sup>The model finds no latent time-varying factors, making it equivalent to a difference-in-differences estimator with staggered adoption.

<sup>31</sup>Logging web traffic is common practice for long-tailed distributions such as web traffic. Nevertheless for robustness we also generated synthetic controls on unlogged quarterly web traffic, and found that results are directionally consistent (effect=956,785) but are not significant at the 95% level because a small number of high-traffic outlets inflate the standard error ( $p = 0.18$ ).

<sup>32</sup>This estimate of unaffiliated die-out roughly aligns with nationwide estimates of newspaper disappearances: Metzger and the Medill Local News Initiative (2025) estimates that 40% of American newspapers disappeared over the 10-year span between 2016 and 2025, about half the time frame of our analysis.

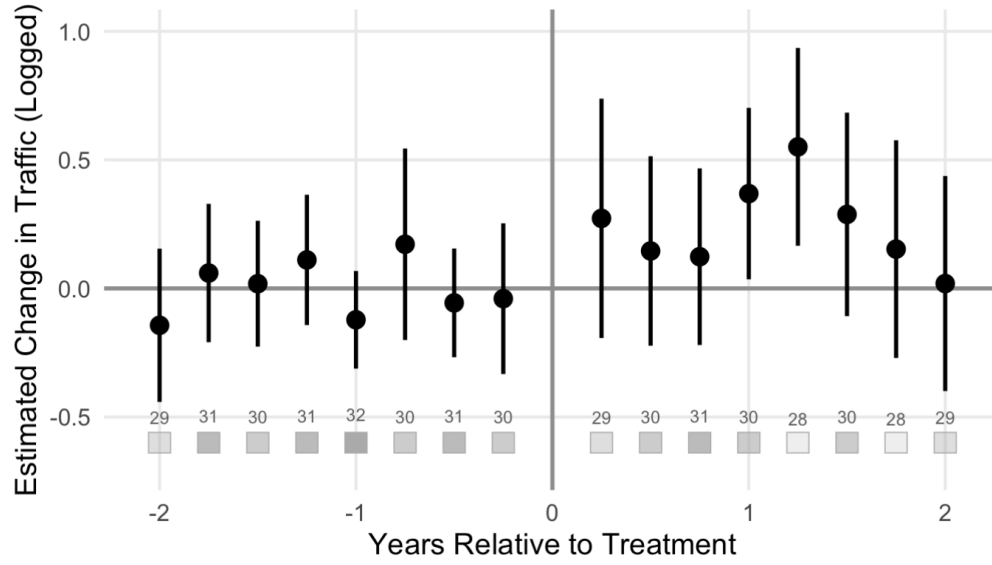


FIGURE 5. ESTIMATED EFFECT OF PRC AFFILIATION ON LOGGED WEB TRAFFIC. VERTICAL LINE REPRESENTS YEAR OF AFFILIATION; EACH DOT IS A QUARTERLY OBSERVATION (PATRONAGE  $n = 32$ , UNAFFILIATED  $n = 62$ ). SHADED BOX REPRESENTS TREATED OUTLET VOLUME.

TABLE 2. COX PROPORTIONAL HAZARDS MODEL

|                      | (1)                      |
|----------------------|--------------------------|
| Affiliated           | 0.428*<br>[0.185, 0.993] |
| Outlet Age           | 0.992+<br>[0.982, 1.002] |
| Num. Obs.            | 3401                     |
| Num. Events          | 128                      |
| LR test ( $\chi^2$ ) | 7.05                     |
| LR $p$ -value        | 0.030                    |

+  $p < 0.1$ , \*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*  $p < 0.01$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.001$

### 5.3. Patronage Reshapes Markets

Together, selection and differential survival reshape the composition of media markets over time. Figure 6 shows the yearly average stance toward China (gray point estimates and confidence intervals), with the over-time linear change in stance overlaid (in red). While early years have wide confidence intervals due to the relatively few outlets for which we have data in those years, the overall trend is positive, with a dip between 2020 and 2023 (coinciding with the outbreak of Covid-19). By the end of our data collection, 128 of 193 outlets had accepted PRC patronage. Overall, the outlets in our sample produced 1.4% more positive stories about China annually (25.9% over the full period).<sup>33</sup>

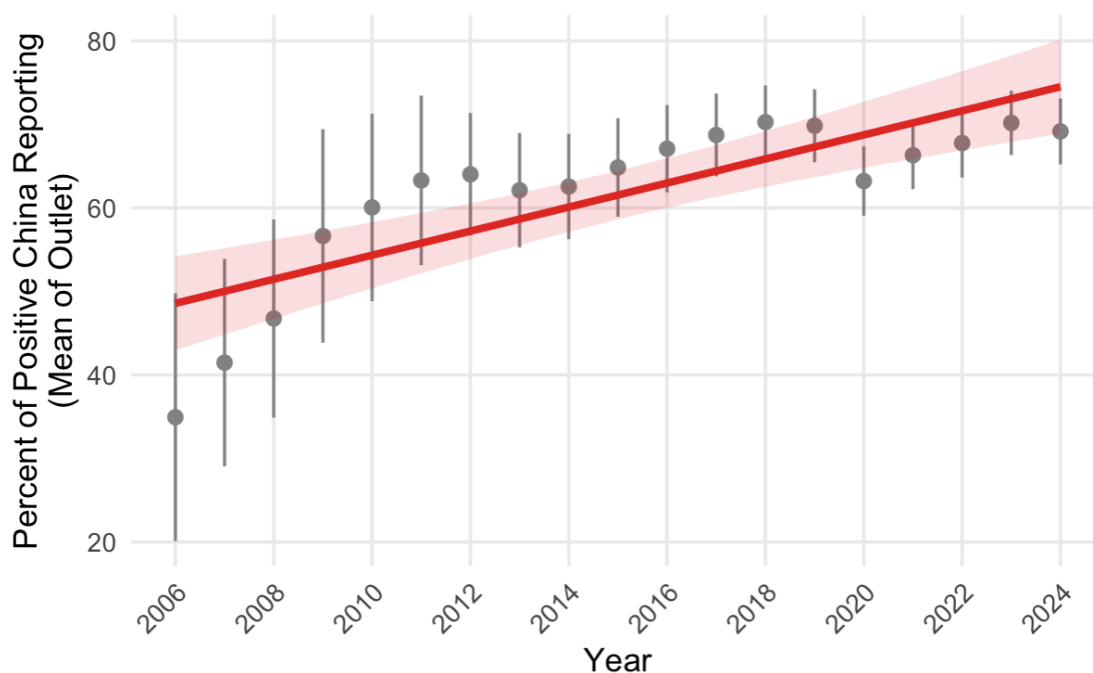


FIGURE 6. PERCENT OF COVERAGE THAT IS POSITIVE TOWARD CHINA GLOBALLY, AVERAGE OF OUTLETS

<sup>33</sup>This rise is partially associated with the entrance of new outlets with a higher share of positive stories. Unaffiliated outlets over this period grow less positive about China (See Appendix A3.4), but changes in the ecosystem composition offset this diminished within-outlet positivity.

## 6. Domestic Implications of Patronage for China

In addition to international objectives such as increasing soft power or strengthening public diplomacy, patronage may also mitigate global media outlets’ threat to domestic information control—and in particular preventing them from helping to coordinate collective action (Guriev and Treisman 2019; King, Pan and Roberts 2013). This threat is particularly acute during political crises, as the increased demand for credible information leads citizens to exert greater effort to seek foreign information sources (Chang et al. 2022; Chen and Yang 2019). We examine the case of China’s White Paper Protests in late 2022, China’s most widespread public protests since the Tiananmen Incident in 1989, to explore whether patronage benefits domestic information control. Specifically, we examine both the production and reception of global Chinese-language news in the 40 days surrounding China’s White Paper protests (November 1 to December 10, 2022). On the production side, 154 of 193 outlets in the Global Dataset published in this period (total of 146,055 articles). On the reception side, we use a Chinese public opinion monitoring dataset that tracks hundreds of millions of posts daily across all major Chinese social media platforms to identify outlets’ domains and Chinese-language names, yielding 81,511 posts referencing 106 organizations.<sup>34</sup> We identify protest coverage using keyword searches for terms associated with the White Paper protests and the Zero-COVID policy.<sup>35</sup>

We find that of outlets publishing 10 or more articles over this period, patronage outlets ( $n = 78$ ) were much less likely to mention public discontent or protests when covering China’s Zero-COVID policy, with only 18.5% of Zero-COVID related stories mentioning

<sup>34</sup>In instances where names were a subset of each other (e.g. *Meiguo Huaren Zhoubao* 美国华人周报 and *Huaren Zhoubao* 华人周报) we used greedy matching to match the superset but not the subset. In instances where news organization names were identical (e.g. *Ouzhou Ribao* 欧洲日报) and thus posts could refer to multiple organizations, we used news organization country of origin to disambiguate between matching titles. If multiple countries were mentioned, we concluded that we were unable to disambiguate and removed them.  $n = 7484$  posts could not be disambiguated and were removed from the analysis.

<sup>35</sup>As of September 2026 we are in the process of hand-labeling a validation set for use in a machine-learning pipeline to replace this keyword pipeline. Searched keywords were “protest” (抗议), “demonstration” (示威), “public procession” (游行), “white paper” (白纸), “reopening” (解封), “zero-COVID policy” (清零), “Urumqi” (where the fire that accelerated the protests took place, 乌鲁木齐), and “Xinjiang fire” (新疆火灾).

discontent, compared to 51.9% of unaffiliated outlets ( $n = 69$ ).<sup>36</sup> Those outlets were also over-represented in China relative to their global traffic volume. Among the 106 outlets that are mentioned in the Chinese public opinion monitoring dataset, patronage and unaffiliated coverage circulated at similar rates (patronage *mean* = 847, *median* = 101,  $n = 52$ ; unaffiliated *mean* = 693, *median* = 85,  $n = 54$ ) despite unaffiliated outlets receiving almost five times as many website visits globally as patronage outlets during a similar time (patronage=352,702, unaffiliated=1,532,940,  $p = 0.037$ ).<sup>37</sup> In other words, patronage outlets are visible domestically in China far beyond what their global audience size would suggest.

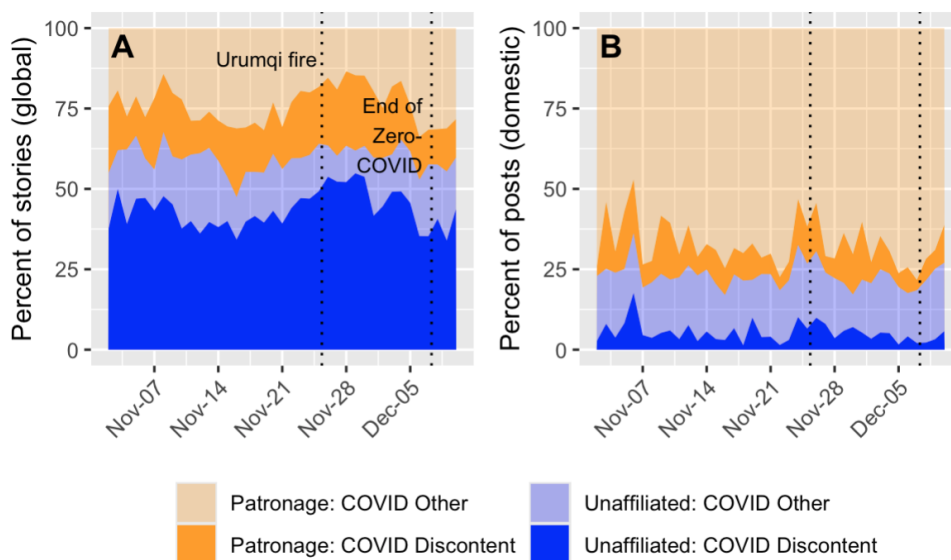


FIGURE 7. NEWS COVERAGE DURING THE ZERO-COVID PROTESTS NOV-DEC 2022.

DOTTED LINES INDICATE THE BEGINNING AND END OF WIDESPREAD ZERO-COVID PROTESTS. PANEL A: PERCENT OF ALL STORIES PRODUCED. PANEL B: PERCENT OF POSTS IN DOMESTIC CIRCULATION.

Patronage outlets' over-representation in China, relative to their global audience share, means that unaffiliated outlets' protest coverage formed a smaller share of Chinese domestic circulation of foreign Chinese-language covid news during this White Paper protest period.

<sup>36</sup>Of the 69 unaffiliated outlets at the time of the protests in 2022, 24 of them will later become affiliated.

<sup>37</sup>The difference in outlet means in the public opinion monitoring dataset is not statistically significant (Welch Two Sample t-test,  $p = 0.759$ ). Results are consistent for mean of logged visits (patronage=7.24, unaffiliated=9.40,  $p = 0.032$ ).

Figure 7 shows protest-related Zero-COVID coverage from both types of outlets (Panel A), as well as how that coverage circulated domestically over the same time period (Panel B). Despite being a minority of global Zero-COVID coverage, patronage outlets' coverage of Zero-COVID was much more likely to circulate in China during the white paper period, with non-protest related coverage forming 73.6% of all foreign mentions of China's Zero-COVID policy. Only 12.3% of posts mentioning patronage outlets discussed discontent, compared to 34.8% of posts mentioning unaffiliated outlets.

## 7. Discussion

This paper argues that authoritarian regimes can shape global news production by altering the economics of news supply to effect changes in the global information ecosystem. Across the new data we collected for this project, we find that the CCP uses media patronage to selectively sponsor news organizations with a pro-regime slant; patronage preserves existing pro-regime coverage; and PRC-linked organizations survive longer than outlets who do not receive state support. Over time, the pro-China reporting has increased in the global market for Chinese-language news. During crises, Covid coverage from these PRC-linked organizations omitted more public discontent, and circulated more widely domestically, than similar coverage from unaffiliated organizations.

Media patronage helps the CCP preserve pro-regime outlets while anti-regime outlets die out due to existing global financial strains on local news. By using business transactions rather than overt repression or co-optation, political, reputational, and financial risks are diminished while achieving global changes in news production. Theoretically, these behaviors are consistent with the rise of “information autocrats” who seek to use lower-visibility tactics—in our case, market mechanisms—to undercut opposition without resorting to direct repression (Guriev and Treisman 2019). We identify additional evidence for such regimes in a transnational context.

While our study examines media patronage transnationally, the scope conditions of media

patronage may exist in low-capacity authoritarian regimes and media institutions within their own borders. Where the state lacks capacity to enforce a command relationship with local media actors, or has limited ability to monitor local affairs, it is conceivable that they may turn to patronage to pursue state interests in the absence of the state’s unmediated presence. Indeed, such an approach bears similarities to recent work on the use of “proxy media” in an African context, where private intermediaries help to conceal the state’s role in influencing seemingly-independent press coverage ([Rahmani 2025](#)).

Our findings suggest that, in addition to nurturing media independence during boom times ([Gentzkow, Glaeser and Goldin 2006](#); [Petrova 2011](#)), markets can also facilitate authoritarian influence when media markets are in crisis. In the absence of government support—a hallmark of media independence in democracies—media organizations under strain turn to other backers to ensure their survival. Autocrats’ willingness to fund foreign news, in turn, creates a structural advantage for autocracies in the market for news: pro-regime voices can find wealthy patrons while anti-regime voices cannot. This dynamic is associated with a rise in authoritarian influence on media production even outside territorial boundaries.

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# Appendix

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## A1. Data

### A1.1. Global Dataset Data Availability

| Outlet |                | Founded | Wayback From | Scrape From | Patronage |
|--------|----------------|---------|--------------|-------------|-----------|
| ID     | Country        |         |              |             |           |
| 1      | USA            | 1851    | 2012         | 2012        | 0         |
| 2      | United Kingdom | 1888    | 2003         | 2005        | 0         |
| 3      | USA            | 1889    | 2008         | 2014        | 0         |
| 4      | Malaysia       | 1910    | 1998         | 2023        | 1         |
| 5      | Philippines    | 1919    | 2012         | 2011        | 1         |
| 6      | Korea          | 1920    | 2014         | 2012        | 0         |
| 7      | Malaysia       | 1923    | 2015         | 2016        | 1         |
| 8      | Malaysia       | 1929    | 2002         | 2007        | 1         |
| 9      | Malaysia       | 1936    | 2024         | 2009        | 0         |
| 10     | Malaysia       | 1946    | 2000         | 2017        | 1         |
| 11     | Thailand       | 1950    | 2014         | 2017        | 1         |
| 12     | Malaysia       | 1952    | 2009         | 2014        | 0         |
| 13     | Brazil         | 1960    | 2004         | 2011        | 1         |
| 14     | Korea          | 1965    | 2004         | 2008        | 1         |
| 15     | Malaysia       | 1968    | 2011         | 2018        | 1         |
| 16     | USA            | 1972    | 2021         | 2020        | 0         |
| 17     | Philippines    | 1973    | 2016         | 2023        | 1         |
| 18     | Malaysia       | 1976    | 2002         | 2016        | 1         |
| 19     | USA            | 1976    | 1999         | 2019        | 0         |
| 20     | USA            | 1976    | 2000         | 2020        | 0         |
| 21     | Portugal       | 1977    |              | 2021        | 1         |
| 22     | USA            | 1979    | 2000         | 2019        | 1         |
| 23     | South Korea    | 1980    | 2018         | 2024        | 1         |
| 24     | Indonesia      | 1981    |              | 2020        | 1         |
| 25     | Philippines    | 1981    | 2014         | 2019        | 1         |
| 26     | USA            | 1981    | 2021         | 2021        | 1         |
| 27     | USA            | 1982    | 2004         | 2017        | 0         |
| 28     | Singapore      | 1983    | 1998         | 2016        | 1         |
| 29     | Australia      | 1987    | 2001         | 2019        | 0         |
| 30     | Malaysia       | 1987    | 2003         | 2021        | 1         |
| 31     | USA            | 1989    | 2008         | 2021        | 0         |
| 32     | USA            | 1991    | 2020         | 2020        | 1         |
| 33     | USA            | 1990    | 2019         | 2019        | 1         |
| 34     | USA            | 1990    | 2010         | 2017        | 1         |
| 35     | USA            | 1990    | 2004         | 2012        | 1         |
| 36     | USA            | 1990    | 2007         | 2022        | 1         |
| 37     | New Zealand    | 1991    | 2004         | 2022        | 1         |
| 38     | Australia      | 1992    | 2008         | 2024        | 0         |

| Outlet |                | Founded | Wayback From | Scrape From | Patronage |
|--------|----------------|---------|--------------|-------------|-----------|
| ID     | Country        |         |              |             |           |
| 39     | Japan          | 1992    | 1997         | 2006        | 1         |
| 40     | Netherlands    | 1992    | 2002         | 2023        | 1         |
| 41     | Australia      | 1994    | 2014         | 2013        | 0         |
| 42     | New Zealand    | 1994    |              | 2016        | 1         |
| 43     | USA            | 1994    | 2003         | 2024        | 1         |
| 44     | USA            | 1994    | 2015         | 2010        | 1         |
| 45     | Canada         | 1995    | 1998         | 2023        | 0         |
| 46     | USA            | 1995    | 2017         | 2017        | 1         |
| 47     | Japan          | 1996    | 2021         | 2022        | 1         |
| 48     | Germany        | 1997    | 2022         | 2017        | 1         |
| 49     | USA            | 1997    | 2008         | 2017        | 0         |
| 50     | USA            | 1997    | 1998         | 2014        | 1         |
| 51     | USA            | 1997    | 1998         | 2003        | 0         |
| 52     | Canada         | 1998    | 1999         | 2006        | 0         |
| 53     | New Zealand    | 1998    | 2008         | 2021        | 1         |
| 54     | USA            | 1998    | 2004         | 2021        | 0         |
| 55     | Canada         | 1999    | 2005         | 2004        | 0         |
| 56     | Hungary        | 1999    | 2013         | 2014        | 1         |
| 57     | Japan          | 1999    | 2020         | 2003        | 1         |
| 58     | Malaysia       | 1999    |              | 2005        | 0         |
| 59     | Romania        | 1999    | 2016         | 2013        | 1         |
| 60     | USA            | 1999    | 2021         | 2018        | 1         |
| 61     | Cambodia       | 2000    | 2010         | 2018        | 1         |
| 62     | England        | 2000    | 2016         | 2022        | 0         |
| 63     | Hungary        | 2000    | 2001         | 2013        | 1         |
| 64     | Indonesia      | 2000    |              | 2018        | 0         |
| 65     | Indonesia      | 2000    | 2011         | 2024        | 1         |
| 66     | Indonesia      | 2000    | 2010         | 2020        | 1         |
| 67     | Peru           | 2000    |              | 2021        | 1         |
| 68     | Romania        | 2000    | 2013         | 2013        | 1         |
| 69     | Russia         | 2000    | 2014         | 2014        | 1         |
| 70     | United Kingdom | 2000    | 2017         | 2019        | 1         |
| 71     | USA            | 2000    | 2000         | 2001        | 0         |
| 72     | Global         | 2000    | 2004         | 2023        | 1         |
| 73     | Canada         | 2001    | 2003         | 2023        | 1         |
| 74     | Canada         | 2001    | 2011         | 2021        | 1         |
| 75     | Canada         | 2001    | 2001         | 2024        | 0         |
| 76     | Japan          | 2002    | 2017         | 2016        | 1         |
| 77     | New Zealand    | 2001    | 2003         | 2018        | 1         |
| 78     | USA            | 2001    | 2017         | 2019        | 0         |
| 79     | USA            | 2001    | 2001         | 2001        | 0         |
| 80     | USA            | 2001    | 2008         | 2002        | 0         |

| Outlet |                      | Founded | Wayback From | Scrape From | Patronage |
|--------|----------------------|---------|--------------|-------------|-----------|
| ID     | Country              |         |              |             |           |
| 81     | Canada               | 2002    | 2015         | 2015        | 1         |
| 82     | Spain                | 2002    | 2003         | 2016        | 1         |
| 83     | Canada               | 2000    | 2000         | 2003        | 0         |
| 84     | Canada               | 2002    | 2002         | 2023        | 0         |
| 85     | Malaysia             | 2002    | 2002         | 2012        | 1         |
| 86     | Netherlands          | 2003    | 2008         | 2018        | 1         |
| 87     | New Zealand          | 2003    | 2015         | 2017        | 1         |
| 88     | Spain                | 2001    |              | 2010        | 1         |
| 89     | USA                  | 2001    | 2001         | 2019        | 0         |
| 90     | Australia            | 2001    | 2001         | 2021        | 0         |
| 91     | Brunei               | 2004    | 2009         | 2019        | 0         |
| 92     | Italy                | 2004    | 2021         | 2020        | 1         |
| 93     | Singapore            | 2004    | 2009         | 2008        | 1         |
| 94     | USA                  | 2004    | 2017         | 2016        | 1         |
| 95     | USA                  | 2004    | 2010         | 2010        | 0         |
| 96     | USA                  | 2004    | 2005         | 2017        | 0         |
| 97     | France               | 1983    | 2009         | 2009        | 1         |
| 98     | Greece               | 2005    | 2009         | 2009        | 1         |
| 99     | Hungary              | 2005    | 2007         | 2011        | 1         |
| 100    | South Africa         | 2005    | 2017         | 2017        | 1         |
| 101    | South Korea          | 2005    | 2020         | 2020        | 1         |
| 102    | USA                  | 2005    | 2005         | 2011        | 0         |
| 103    | Australia            | 2006    | 2018         | 2017        | 1         |
| 104    | Australia            | 2006    | 2007         | 2010        | 0         |
| 105    | Poland               | 2006    | 2006         | 2006        | 1         |
| 106    | South Korea          | 2006    | 2009         | 2022        | 1         |
| 107    | Canada               | 2007    | 2004         | 2017        | 0         |
| 108    | Myanmar              | 2007    | 2012         | 2012        | 1         |
| 109    | South Korea          | 2007    | 2019         | 2023        | 1         |
| 110    | Italy                | 2008    | 2009         | 2014        | 1         |
| 111    | Portugal             | 2006    |              | 2013        | 1         |
| 112    | South Africa         | 2008    |              | 2008        | 1         |
| 113    | Australia            | 2009    |              | 2021        | 1         |
| 114    | Brazil               | 2009    |              | 2011        | 1         |
| 115    | Canada               | 2009    | 2009         | 2020        | 1         |
| 116    | United Arab Emirates | 2009    | 2010         | 2010        | 1         |
| 117    | Australia            | 2001    | 2001         | 2011        | 1         |
| 118    | Canada               | 2010    | 2012         | 2020        | 0         |
| 119    | Spain                | 2010    | 2008         | 2010        | 1         |
| 120    | United Kingdom       | 2010    | 2012         | 2010        | 1         |
| 121    | USA                  | 2010    | 2021         | 2019        | 1         |
| 122    | USA                  | 2010    | 2010         | 2010        | 1         |

| Outlet |                 | Founded | Wayback From | Scrape From | Patronage |
|--------|-----------------|---------|--------------|-------------|-----------|
| ID     | Country         |         |              |             |           |
| 123    | Argentina       | 2010    | 2010         | 2017        | 1         |
| 124    | Australia       | 2006    | 2006         | 2018        | 1         |
| 125    | Canada          | 2008    | 2008         | 2017        | 1         |
| 126    | France          | 2011    | 2011         | 2011        | 1         |
| 127    | Italy           | 2011    | 2012         | 2017        | 1         |
| 128    | Philippines     | 2011    | 2016         | 2020        | 1         |
| 129    | Australia       | 2011    | 2019         | 2012        | 1         |
| 130    | Madagascar      | 2012    | 2024         | 2018        | 1         |
| 131    | Australia       | 2013    | 2015         | 2022        | 1         |
| 132    | France          | 2014    |              | 2023        | 1         |
| 133    | Peru            | 2013    | 2018         | 2016        | 0         |
| 134    | Thailand        | 2013    | 2013         | 2018        | 1         |
| 135    | Australia       | 2014    | 2005         | 2016        | 0         |
| 136    | Indonesia       | 2014    | 2018         | 2018        | 1         |
| 137    | Mexico          | 2014    |              | 2021        | 1         |
| 138    | United Kingdom  | 2002    | 2013         | 2018        | 1         |
| 139    | Canada          | 2015    | 2011         | 2016        | 0         |
| 140    | Chile           | 2015    | 2015         | 2019        | 1         |
| 141    | Singapore       | 2007    | 2007         | 2015        | 0         |
| 142    | The Netherlands | 2015    | 2015         | 2022        | 1         |
| 143    | USA             | 2011    | 2011         | 2021        | 0         |
| 144    | Australia       | 2016    | 2017         | 2016        | 0         |
| 145    | Brazil          | 2016    | 2023         | 2021        | 1         |
| 146    | Egypt           | 2012    | 2013         | 2020        | 1         |
| 147    | New Zealand     | 2016    | 2018         | 2019        | 1         |
| 148    | Pakistan        | 2016    |              | 2021        | 1         |
| 149    | South Korea     | 2016    | 2016         | 2017        | 1         |
| 150    | Sweden          | 2009    | 2015         | 2018        | 1         |
| 151    | USA             | 2015    | 2021         | 2015        | 0         |
| 152    | Cambodia        | 2018    | 2019         | 2023        | 1         |
| 153    | Canada          | 2017    | 2011         | 2017        | 1         |
| 154    | Singapore       | 2011    | 2011         | 2018        | 0         |
| 155    | Germany         | 2020    |              | 2020        | 0         |
| 156    | New Zealand     | 2020    | 2021         | 2020        | 1         |
| 157    | USA             | 2020    | 2015         | 2020        | 0         |
| 158    | Greece          | 2017    | 2023         | 2017        | 1         |
| 159    | United Kingdom  | 2022    |              | 2022        | 0         |
| 160    | Cambodia        | 2022    | 2022         | 2022        | 1         |
| 161    | Hong Kong       | 2022    |              | 2022        | 0         |
| 162    | Global          | 2022    |              | 2023        | 0         |
| 163    | Australia       | 2014    | 2014         | 2017        | 1         |
| 164    | Australia       | 2021    | 2021         | 2021        | 0         |

| Outlet |             | Founded | Wayback From | Scrape From | Patronage |
|--------|-------------|---------|--------------|-------------|-----------|
| ID     | Country     |         |              |             |           |
| 165    | Australia   | 2017    | 2017         | 2020        | 0         |
| 166    | Cambodia    | 2017    | 2017         | 2017        | 1         |
| 167    | Cambodia    | 1992    | 2016         | 2010        | 1         |
| 168    | Canada      |         | 2021         |             | 0         |
| 169    | Canada      | 2005    | 2010         | 2015        | 1         |
| 170    | Canada      | 2008    | 2008         | 2008        | 1         |
| 171    | Canada      | 2002    | 2004         | 2024        | 0         |
| 172    | Canada      | 2023    |              | 2023        | 1         |
| 173    | Indonesia   | 2007    | 2012         | 2020        | 1         |
| 174    | Italy       | 2006    | 2018         | 2019        | 1         |
| 175    | Italy       | 2004    | 2017         | 2010        | 1         |
| 176    | Japan       | 2010    | 2010         | 2015        | 1         |
| 177    | Japan       | 2018    |              | 2018        | 1         |
| 178    | Malaysia    | 2012    |              | 2012        | 1         |
| 179    | Malaysia    | 2017    |              | 2017        | 0         |
| 180    | Netherlands | 2014    | 2015         | 2016        | 1         |
| 181    | Singapore   | 2014    | 2014         | 2014        | 0         |
| 182    | Singapore   | 2018    | 2018         | 2018        | 0         |
| 183    | Thailand    | 2024    | 2024         | 2024        | 0         |
| 184    | Thailand    | 2008    | 2012         | 2009        | 1         |
| 185    | Ukraine     | 2002    | 2006         | 2016        | 1         |
| 186    | USA         | 2001    | 2015         | 2014        | 0         |
| 187    | USA         | 1992    | 2021         | 2017        | 1         |
| 188    | USA         | 2014    | 2015         | 2014        | 1         |
| 189    | USA         | 1965    | 2001         | 2021        | 0         |
| 190    | USA         | 2021    | 2021         | 2021        | 0         |
| 191    | Venezuela   | 1999    |              | 2020        | 1         |
| 192    | Global      | 1997    | 1998         | 2022        | 0         |
| 193    | Global      | 1998    | 1999         | 2017        | 0         |

## A1.2. US Census Dataset Construction

Data on historical Chinese-language newspapers are drawn from four sources. The first is the Him Mark Lai Collection at U.C. Berkeley, a record of Chinese-language newspaper clippings and newspapers records recorded by Him Mark Lai (1925 - 2009), a San Francisco-based historian of Chinese life in the United States (Lai 2009). The second is the Library of Congress’ “Chronicling America” collection of historic newspapers in the United States, which maintains a limited database of Chinese-American newspapers (Library of Congress 2026). The third is Ma (2003)’s excellent database of Chinese American Newspapers and Periodicals in the U.S. in 2003. The fourth is a 2014 P.R. Newswire index of Chinese-language media organizations in the United States.<sup>1</sup> Many outlets appeared in two or more of these sources.

To determine whether a newspaper was active in the United States, we adopted broader criteria than for the Global Dataset due to data scarcity concerns. In many cases it was challenging to determine conclusively where an organization was based and what it published about. In the end, we adopted the rule that if an outlet was: (A) publishing news, AND (B1) had staff based in the United States; OR (B2) published news about United States affairs drawn from a local correspondent, we considered the outlet active in the United States. If we could not view historical content but an outlet was described as a “newspaper” or “news organization”, we assumed that it produced general interest news. If an outlet was absorbed by another outlet, we considered that outlet closed. If an outlet remained active outside the U.S. (e.g. in Hong Kong) but the U.S. operations ceased, we also considered an outlet closed. If an outlet once had a U.S. correspondent but we were unable to determine whether the correspondent had left, we considered it “active” if the overall organization was still producing news. If an outlet was a radio station dedicated to Chinese-language content we included it; if an outlet was a radio channel (within a non-Chinese language station) we excluded it. Finally, as with the Global Dataset, if the historical news organization openly acknowledged ownership by a state actor (e.g. *People’s Daily*), we excluded it.

To determine the date of closure, we adopted the following criteria:

1. If the date of outlet’s closure was published in archival materials or announced publicly by the outlet itself, we used that. If not:
2. A team of two research assistants (RAs) sought to determine via open source methods the date an outlet closed. If that date was available, we used it. If not:
3. We checked the Wayback Machine for the last date an outlet’s website was available, and used that as the date of closure. If the outlet did not appear in the Wayback Machine:
4. We used the last issue for each newspaper saved in archival resources, or the date 2014 if the PR newswire report was the last mention of the outlet on the internet. If one collection contained a later date than the other, we used the later date as an outlet’s official end date.

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<sup>1</sup><https://www.webwire.com/prnewswire/PDF/384.pdf>, Accessed March 25 2026

Because the criteria for inclusion in the historical dataset was broader than the news-domain dataset, the two datasets have different counts of active outlets in the U.S. during 2024, the study’s onset. Of the 93 outlets active in the U.S. as of the end of 2024, 38 are in our news domain dataset while 55 are not. The remaining 55 were not included for several reasons. In nine cases, the outlet was based outside the U.S. (usually Hong Kong or Taiwan) but maintained a U.S.-based correspondent. An additional nine outlets produced, or could not be disproven as having produced, general interest news at some point prior to 2024 but no longer produce general interest news today. Eighteen outlets had no digital presence or produced only digital scanned copies of print newspapers, which were not scrapeable and thus excluded from the Global Dataset. The remaining 19 outlets appear to have been active in 2024 but were not included in the initial domain gathering process because they were not surfaced using the methods described in Section 3.

### A1.3. Data Cleaning

For each full-text article we adopted the following cleaning and normalization steps:

- Removed stray encoding characters (e.g. sp?).
- Converted traditional Chinese characters to simplified characters
- Removed articles with impossible publication dates (e.g. prior to the invention of the internet or in the future).
- Filtered out articles containing less than 10% Chinese characters.

For each archived webpage snapshot, all hyperlinks (`<a>`) and image links (`<img>`) were extracted. Each link was recorded with associated metadata, including the snapshot date, the link itself, the element type (anchor or image), the order in which the tag appeared on the page, and any human-readable anchor text.

To ensure data quality, we applied a series of data-cleaning steps:

- Removed all self-references (e.g., homepage links to the same outlet).
- Removed vestigial Wayback Machine or Archive.org links.
- Removed JavaScript anchors and invalid domains (restricted to valid alphanumeric domain names with a top-level domain).
- Removed external links where a domain was referenced only once across the entire corpus (suggesting they functioned as self-links).
- Expanded shortened URLs using a comprehensive list of URL shorteners;<sup>2</sup> replaced the original shortened link with the expanded form, and re-ran domain lookups on the expanded addresses.
- Identified and removed advertising links, social media profile links, and social-sharing links using regular-expression matching.
- Consolidated domains where only the top-level domain differed (e.g., treating `example.com` and `example.net` as equivalent self-links).

To assign countries of origin to extracted URL domains, we employed a tiered procedure. Each domain was first queried against the most authoritative source available; if that approach failed, we proceeded sequentially to the next. Specifically:

1. Domains were first manually checked against the ICANN database.
2. If no ICANN record was available, we used the DomainTools API to query country-level registration data.
3. If DomainTools returned no result, we parsed WHOIS records directly.

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<sup>2</sup>see <https://github.com/PeterDaveHello/url-shorteners/blob/master/list>

4. If WHOIS records were unavailable, we parsed Registration Data Access Protocol (RDAP) records.
5. If RDAP data could not be obtained, we consulted WHOIS history records.
6. As a last resort, we inferred the country based on the domain suffix (top-level domain).

Finally, we manually corrected a small number of high-profile cases where automated assignment was misleading. For example, `temu.com` was improperly assigned to the United States, and `weibo.com` was assigned as “Not Applicable.”

## A1.4. Alternate Estimates for Chinese News Consumption

To provide alternate estimates of Chinese news consumption globally, we also look to two additional sources of Chinese-language media consumption: website visits and app downloads.

For website visits, we take the top 50 websites visited by Chinese users in November 2025<sup>3</sup>, and subset to all websites whose interfaces are Chinese by default when accessed from a U.S. IP address. This criterion yields 10 domains. We then use the Semrush Traffic & Analytics Toolkit to download country-by-country annual traffic data for unique visitors to each of the 10 domains from 2017-2024. We then subset to domains present in the data in both 2020 and 2024 in all countries (10 domains), and average the unique visitors to each site.<sup>4</sup> The 10 domains were: taobao.com, 163.com, weibo.com, 360.com, tmall.com, 1688.com, huya.com, douban.com, sohu.com, alipay.com.

For app downloads, we take the top 20 apps in China (by monthly active users), and subset to the 16 apps with current and historic country-by-country download data available from AppFigures.<sup>5</sup> We then average across all 16 apps in each country to get the number of annual app downloads to users located in each country.

The results are largely consistent with the U.N. migration data.

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<sup>3</sup><https://www.semrush.com/trending-websites/cn/all>

<sup>4</sup><https://www.semrush.com/>

<sup>5</sup><https://appinchina.co/market/apps/>; <https://appfigures.com/>

TABLE A2. TOP COUNTRIES BY CHINESE POPULATION AND MEDIA REACH (2020)

| Country        | UN Rank | Traffic Rank | App Rank | Chinese Pop. | Unique Visitors | Downloads |
|----------------|---------|--------------|----------|--------------|-----------------|-----------|
| United States  | 1       | 1            | NA       | 2,255,170    | 6,486,587       | NA        |
| Japan          | 2       | 3            | NA       | 917,070      | 2,309,252       | NA        |
| South Korea    | 3       | 6            | NA       | 751,745      | 998,007         | NA        |
| Canada         | 4       | 5            | NA       | 721,158      | 1,274,896       | NA        |
| Australia      | 5       | 8            | NA       | 632,690      | 884,418         | NA        |
| Singapore      | 6       | 4            | NA       | 509,007      | 2,090,483       | NA        |
| Italy          | 7       | 18           | NA       | 241,671      | 201,844         | NA        |
| United Kingdom | 8       | 10           | NA       | 213,560      | 675,855         | NA        |
| Spain          | 9       | 17           | NA       | 190,373      | 230,712         | NA        |
| Germany        | 10      | 7            | NA       | 152,761      | 896,216         | NA        |
| New Zealand    | 11      | 20           | NA       | 144,287      | 177,153         | NA        |
| France         | 12      | 12           | NA       | 114,237      | 452,734         | NA        |
| Thailand       | 13      | 11           | NA       | 100,327      | 580,086         | NA        |
| Netherlands    | 14      | 16           | NA       | 73,837       | 260,688         | NA        |
| Indonesia      | 15      | 15           | NA       | 47,633       | 265,901         | NA        |
| Sweden         | 16      | 23           | NA       | 35,677       | 113,554         | NA        |
| Brazil         | 18      | 14           | NA       | 32,715       | 273,688         | NA        |
| Malaysia       | 19      | 2            | NA       | 30,606       | 3,057,346       | NA        |
| Philippines    | 20      | 13           | NA       | 27,676       | 274,047         | NA        |
| Russia         | 21      | 9            | NA       | 24,009       | 871,319         | NA        |
| Hungary        | 22      | 35           | NA       | 17,648       | 28,386          | NA        |
| Argentina      | 23      | 28           | NA       | 17,325       | 43,216          | NA        |
| Chile          | 24      | 26           | NA       | 14,364       | 46,112          | NA        |
| Venezuela      | 25      | 37           | NA       | 13,071       | 5,684           | NA        |
| Portugal       | 26      | 33           | NA       | 12,000       | 34,368          | NA        |
| Mexico         | 27      | 21           | NA       | 10,667       | 145,018         | NA        |
| Egypt          | 28      | 29           | NA       | 7,407        | 41,925          | NA        |
| Ukraine        | 29      | 19           | NA       | 6,668        | 192,207         | NA        |
| South Africa   | 30      | 34           | NA       | 6,371        | 30,193          | NA        |
| Peru           | 31      | 31           | NA       | 4,355        | 38,939          | NA        |
| Greece         | 32      | 32           | NA       | 3,462        | 37,840          | NA        |
| Romania        | 33      | 25           | NA       | 2,323        | 51,403          | NA        |
| Brunei         | 34      | 36           | NA       | 2,238        | 10,246          | NA        |
| Madagascar     | 35      | 38           | NA       | 2,193        | 3,086           | NA        |
| Cambodia       | 36      | 27           | NA       | 1,627        | 45,468          | NA        |
| Poland         | 37      | 22           | NA       | 1,069        | 134,173         | NA        |
| Pakistan       | 38      | 24           | NA       | 311          | 54,013          | NA        |

TABLE A3. TOP COUNTRIES BY CHINESE POPULATION AND MEDIA REACH (2024)

| Country        | UN Rank | Traffic Rank | App Rank | Chinese Pop. | Unique Visitors | Downloads  |
|----------------|---------|--------------|----------|--------------|-----------------|------------|
| United States  | 1       | 1            | 1        | 2,488,775    | 11,661,178      | 502077.444 |
| Japan          | 2       | 3            | 5        | 809,893      | 3,943,075       | 87372.636  |
| Canada         | 3       | 10           | 12       | 771,973      | 1,474,382       | 38734.091  |
| South Korea    | 4       | 7            | 4        | 756,684      | 1,934,805       | 90370.500  |
| Australia      | 5       | 6            | 9        | 656,264      | 1,935,462       | 50587.455  |
| Singapore      | 6       | 4            | 7        | 533,745      | 3,558,922       | 63095.167  |
| Italy          | 7       | 20           | 17       | 240,895      | 452,955         | 31517.857  |
| Spain          | 8       | 16           | 19       | 198,909      | 715,942         | 23680.286  |
| United Kingdom | 9       | 11           | 8        | 179,337      | 1,254,851       | 62499.000  |
| Germany        | 10      | 12           | 11       | 168,314      | 1,073,070       | 45214.429  |
| New Zealand    | 11      | 21           | 26       | 145,906      | 416,954         | 8647.000   |
| France         | 12      | 17           | 13       | 120,595      | 652,260         | 37986.750  |
| Thailand       | 13      | 5            | 3        | 85,764       | 2,014,758       | 102455.364 |
| Indonesia      | 14      | 9            | 10       | 82,568       | 1,604,619       | 48229.800  |
| Netherlands    | 15      | 15           | 23       | 82,477       | 856,870         | 12798.750  |
| Sweden         | 16      | 23           | 27       | 40,898       | 191,771         | 7012.000   |
| Egypt          | 18      | 31           | 24       | 34,659       | 95,705          | 11724.000  |
| Malaysia       | 19      | 2            | 6        | 30,524       | 4,688,864       | 87104.667  |
| Philippines    | 20      | 13           | 18       | 27,676       | 991,236         | 31083.000  |
| Brazil         | 21      | 14           | 16       | 24,462       | 976,185         | 33643.000  |
| Hungary        | 22      | 35           | 35       | 20,818       | 65,961          | 2232.800   |
| Argentina      | 23      | 30           | 30       | 19,955       | 98,769          | 4409.875   |
| Russia         | 24      | 8            | 2        | 13,724       | 1,900,487       | 160491.750 |
| Portugal       | 25      | 32           | 29       | 13,500       | 91,559          | 5224.286   |
| Chile          | 26      | 26           | 32       | 13,126       | 124,790         | 3862.444   |
| Venezuela      | 27      | 36           | NA       | 12,470       | 37,424          | NA         |
| Mexico         | 28      | 18           | 20       | 12,070       | 613,278         | 18903.429  |
| Ukraine        | 29      | 22           | 15       | 6,757        | 272,266         | 36704.000  |
| South Africa   | 30      | 33           | 28       | 6,189        | 73,524          | 6330.100   |
| Peru           | 31      | 29           | 33       | 4,560        | 103,535         | 2745.556   |
| Greece         | 32      | 34           | 34       | 3,678        | 69,570          | 2327.625   |
| Pakistan       | 33      | 24           | 22       | 3,568        | 174,199         | 13833.889  |
| Brunei         | 34      | 38           | 36       | 2,397        | 4,769           | 691.900    |
| Madagascar     | 35      | 37           | NA       | 2,382        | 11,319          | NA         |
| Romania        | 36      | 25           | 31       | 2,359        | 152,490         | 4305.429   |
| Cambodia       | 37      | 27           | 14       | 1,721        | 114,568         | 37275.818  |
| Poland         | 38      | 19           | 25       | 703          | 554,059         | 9020.750   |

## A1.5. Qualitative Interviews

All organizations who met the criteria, and for whom contact information was available, were emailed to request an interview. Semi-structured interviews were conducted in Mandarin, English or both. Between October 2024 and February 2026 we spoke with 10 current or former representatives from diasporic media organizations, which yielded 7 oral interviews, 3 written responses to questions, alongside 2 organizations declining an interview and the remainder failing to respond (see Table A4). We contacted media organizations via email

TABLE A4. OVERVIEW OF INTERVIEWS CONDUCTED

| Interview   | Date Conducted | Mode             |
|-------------|----------------|------------------|
| Interview A | October 2024   | In-person (oral) |
| Interview B | November 2024  | In-person (oral) |
| Interview C | March 2025     | Written          |
| Interview D | June 2025      | Phone            |
| Interview E | July 2025      | Written          |
| Interview F | July 2025      | Phone            |
| Interview G | August 2025    | In-person        |
| Interview H | November 2025  | Phone            |
| Interview I | November 2025  | Phone            |
| Interview J | February 2026  | Written          |

accounts or submission portals located on news organization websites. We contacted a total of 151 news organizations for interviews (all outlets for which contact information was available); each oral interview lasted between 30 and 60 minutes, and were conducted on Zoom, telephone, and in-person, and were conducted in either English, Mandarin Chinese, or a mixture of both. Our questions concerned organizational policies and practices, including news selection, target audiences, editorial decisions, and partnerships with domestic Chinese organizations. We applied for IRB approval from Stanford University (Protocol number: 76683) and were informed that because our study investigates organizations, it does not meet the definition of Human Subjects Research as codified in federal regulations at 45 CFR 46 and thus IRB approval was not required.

## A2. Methods

### A2.1. Coding rules

In this project, we are examining how diasporic Chinese media outlets (Chinese-language media organizations based outside of mainland China) report on China. We will ask you to read the titles of several news articles, as well as the first paragraph if necessary, and we will ask you to evaluate each article on a number of different dimensions (listed and described below). If the lede contains additional details that are unrelated to the title of the article, do not consider those additional details.

You will be filling in four columns:

- Related to China (1, 0).
- Related to Host Country (1, 0).
- If Related to China  $\neq$  0: Stance\_C (-1, 0, 1).

**1. Related to China:**     • (1) if the article is related to China (the nation, its government, institutions or policies, territory, or any event that occurs in mainland China, or a multinational organization in which the country participates).

- “Institution” refers to any state-owned or state-operated institution, and any individuals or policies affiliated with that institution.
- State-owned Chinese companies, such as steel manufacturers or banks, are considered a “Chinese” institution even if operating abroad.
- If an individual appears in a formal capacity representing China (the country), then code (1).

- (0) if the article is unrelated to China.

**2. Related to Host Country:**     • (1) if the article is related to the host country (the nation, its government, institutions or politics, territory, or any event that occurs in the host country, or a multinational organization in which the country participates).

- “Institution” same as above; “individuals” representing the host country same as above.

- (0) if the article is unrelated to the host country.

**3. Stance\_C (only if Related to China  $\neq$  0):**     • (1) if the article is supportive of the Chinese Communist Party, the Chinese government, its leaders, its institutions, or its policies; OR likely to leave a reader with a positive impression of the People’s Republic of China. (Note: Chinese culture, language, or history is not necessarily related to the Chinese government.)

- (-1) if the article is critical of the Chinese Communist Party, the Chinese government, its leaders, its institutions, or its policies; OR likely to leave the reader with a negative impression of the People’s Republic of China.
- (0) if the article is neutral (neither supportive nor critical), or unlikely to positively or negatively influence the reader’s impression of the People’s Republic of China.

## A2.2. Article classification

Our hand-labeled sample was generated via stratified sampling by outlet and year. To ensure that our sample was not dominated by outlets with large numbers of articles, we took 1% or 50 articles from each outlet (whichever is greater), with a maximum of 500 articles per outlet. Two trained, independent human coders read the title and lede (first 500 characters) of all articles, determining both whether an article was related to the People’s Republic of China (1 or 0) and, if related, the stance of that article’s stance toward China (-1, 0, or 1). After refining the codebook (see Appendix A2.1), we achieved an intercoder agreement of 95.2% on China relevance and 81.8% on stance toward China ( $n = 100$ ), indicating sufficient construct validity. These coders then coded a total of 1,600 articles for China relevance and stance toward China. Because only about a third of articles relate to China, our gold-standard set of China-stance labels was relatively limited ( $n = 654$ ).

In the second step, we fine-tuned a supervised learning model (DeBERTa) based on the human coded data to classify the remainder of the dataset. After testing multiple models, we found the best performing model to be Erlangshen-DeBERTa-v2-320M-Chinese,<sup>6</sup> a DeBERTa model trained on the WuDao Corpora with whole word masking.<sup>7</sup> Using a 80/20 train-test split, we achieved a binary F1 of 0.91 on our holdout set ( $n = 250$ ) on the China relevance outcome, indicating strong model performance.

In our third step, we used large language models to assess the stance of China-related articles. Due to the small number of hand-labeled China-related articles, we felt using DeBERTa model to apply surrogate stance labels ran the risk of overfitting. We thus turned to large language models (LLMs). While the use of large language models in data-labeling is still relatively new, a few best practices have emerged: use a set checkpoint, set model randomness (“temperature”) to zero, validate against human labels, and run the model repeatedly on the same data to ensure reproducibility (Le Mens and Gallego 2025; Ornstein, Blasingame and Truscott 2025). After following these best practices, we found GPT to be the best performing model family. Yet even after adopting these best practices and experimenting with multiple checkpoints, we found that the best performing model checkpoint at a reasonable cost (gpt-4o-mini-2024-07-18) still performed inadequately when detecting stances, displaying an “agreement bias” where it affirmed whatever category label was posed to it in the prompt. To compensate, we collapsed our three stance categories into two, with “1” representing “positive” coverage while “0” represented “negative or neutral”. After this amendment, GPT’s labels achieved satisfactory agreement with human labels (F1=0.89). Because querying GPT for all China-related articles in our dataset would be prohibitively expensive, we once again sampled from larger outlets (>10,000 observations) while preserving all articles from few observations; we performed sampling on 62 of 193 outlets. We then twice queried gpt-4o-mini to assess stance toward China for a sample of China-related articles in our dataset; approximately 5% of rows received different labels from each GPT run. For disagreements, we performed a third GPT run to break the tie. After obtaining stance labels for all outlets, we calculate the stance measure by aggregating annually for each outlet the average percent of articles each year with positive stance toward China.

<sup>6</sup><https://huggingface.co/IDEA-CCNL/Erlangshen-DeBERTa-v2-320M-Chinese>

<sup>7</sup>The WudaoCorpora is a large (5TB) Chinese-language pre-training corpus compiled by the Beijing Academy of Artificial Intelligence and used widely in Chinese-language artificial intelligence research (Xue et al. 2022).

### **A2.3. Local News Classification**

To classify local news coverage, two trained independent coders assessed whether each article covers news relating to the publishing outlet’s residence country, where “local” means news pertaining to the organization’s country of residence rather than China. We were able to identify residence countries for 188 of 193 outlets; outlets with unknown residence countries were excluded from this analysis. After achieving human inter-coder agreement of 89.4%, we fine-tuned a DeBERTa model using the hand-labeled data to label remaining articles, achieving an F1 of 0.92 on our holdout set.

## A2.4. Error Propagation

Our final labels contain three sources of error. Two are measurement errors: the first results from DeBERTa’s misclassification of news article relevance, while the second results from GPT’s misclassification of China-related articles’ stances toward China. The third is sampling error for the 62 outlets from which we analyzed only 10% of articles. We treat DeBERTa’s China-relevance classifications (the first error) as defining our analysis sample and do not propagate this source of uncertainty in our confidence intervals. In effect, our sample thus includes approximately 5.2% false positives (non-China articles misclassified as China-related) and excludes approximately 16.1% of true China articles (false negatives). We lack sentiment labels for articles DeBERTa classified as non-China-related, making it infeasible to fully propagate DeBERTa classification uncertainty without additional labeling that is prohibitively costly. We propagate the latter two sources of error using a non-parametric bootstrap procedure (1000 iterations) that accounts for GPT sentiment classification error by randomly flipping the label classifications at the same rate as the classifier error rate (FPR: 13.7%, FNR: 8.6%, estimated from five independent validation runs) and accounts for sampling error by re-sampling from outlets where only 10% of articles were analyzed. After each iteration we recalculate the outcome variables and construct confidence intervals from this bootstrapped range of values.

## A2.5. Censored Topics

To identify topics censored in China, we adopted dictionaries of Chinese-language keywords and phrases. Each topic label was assigned based on the presence of one or more of the following terms in article titles or full text using regex.

**Falun Gong:** 法轮功, 李洪志, 法轮大法

**Tiananmen Massacre:** 天安门事件, 天安门屠杀, 天安门大屠杀, 六四事件, 六四屠杀, 六四

**Dalai Lama** 达赖喇嘛, 丹增嘉措

**Xinjiang concentration camps:** Articles that contain the term 新疆 (Xinjiang) together with at least one of the following: 集中营 (concentration camp), 再教育营 (re-education camp), 强制劳动 / 强迫劳动 (forced labor), 压迫 (oppression), 文化灭绝 (cultural extermination), 拘禁 / 拘押 (detention), 人权 (human rights), 宗教压制 (religious suppression), 种族清洗 (ethnic cleansing), 失踪 (disappearance).

## A3. Additional Analysis

### A3.1. Repression and Exit: The Case of Hong Kong

Hong Kong media outlets offer suggestive evidence about the consequences of direct repression on media outlets rather than patronage. In 2020, the PRC government passed the Hong Kong national security law, establishing punishments for secession, subversion, terrorism and collusion with foreign organizations, the stipulations of which were soon applied to local media organizations. Hong Kong’s media freedom declined precipitously in the years after the law’s passage, dropping 80 places in Reporters Without Borders’ Freedom Index and prompting widespread self-censorship among the media (Reporters Without Borders 2025). Our data (see Figure A1) confirms that the crackdown coincided with an increase in positive reporting toward China in Hong Kong media. All Hong Kong media outlets increased the percentage of positive China stories in the wake of the crackdown. However, Figure A1 also depicts the birth of several new “dissident” media outlets based outside of Hong Kong that trace their origin to the Hong Kong crackdown, and are staffed by journalists who fled Hong Kong in the wake of the crackdown.<sup>8</sup> These outlets are characterized by a much lower fraction of positive stories about China, with no dissident outlet surpassing more than 25% positive China stories. While this evidence is only suggestive, it indicates that physical repression — coupled with territorial control — may succeed in changing news coverage, but may also lead to backlash in the form of new critical outlets.

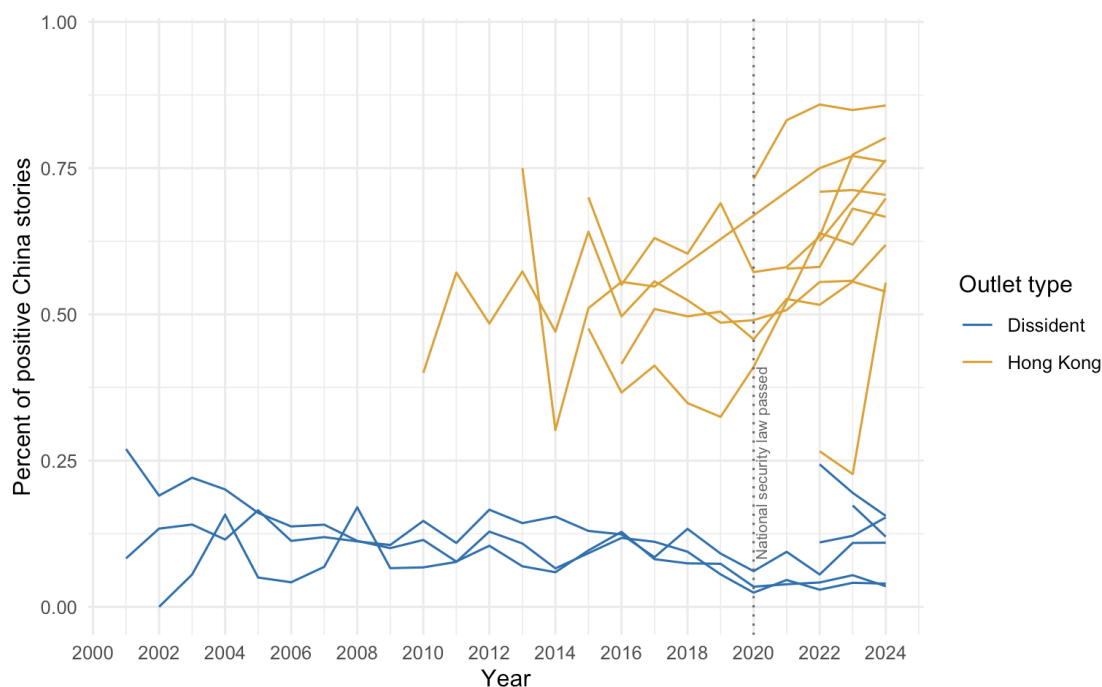


FIGURE A1. HONG KONG AND DISSIDENT MEDIA OUTLETS IN THE WAKE OF THE 2020 NATIONAL SECURITY LAW; OUTLETS WITH FEWER THAN 250 STORIES ANNUALLY OMITTED

<sup>8</sup>We operationalize “dissident” media as outlets whose “About us” page or founding mission states an explicit opposition to the CCP.

### A3.2. Local News Stance

Patronage outlets are not negative toward the host countries where they are reporting. Using the same DeBERTa pipeline described in Appendix A2.2 and A2.1, we also assess the percentage of outlets' article stances that are negative to the country in which the newspapers are located. (1 is negative; 0 is neutral/positive.) We find that there is no change to newspaper coverage after receiving PRC patronage. Comparing the two years pre and post affiliation (dropping the year of affiliation), a paired t-test reveals no significant difference in negativity post-affiliation.

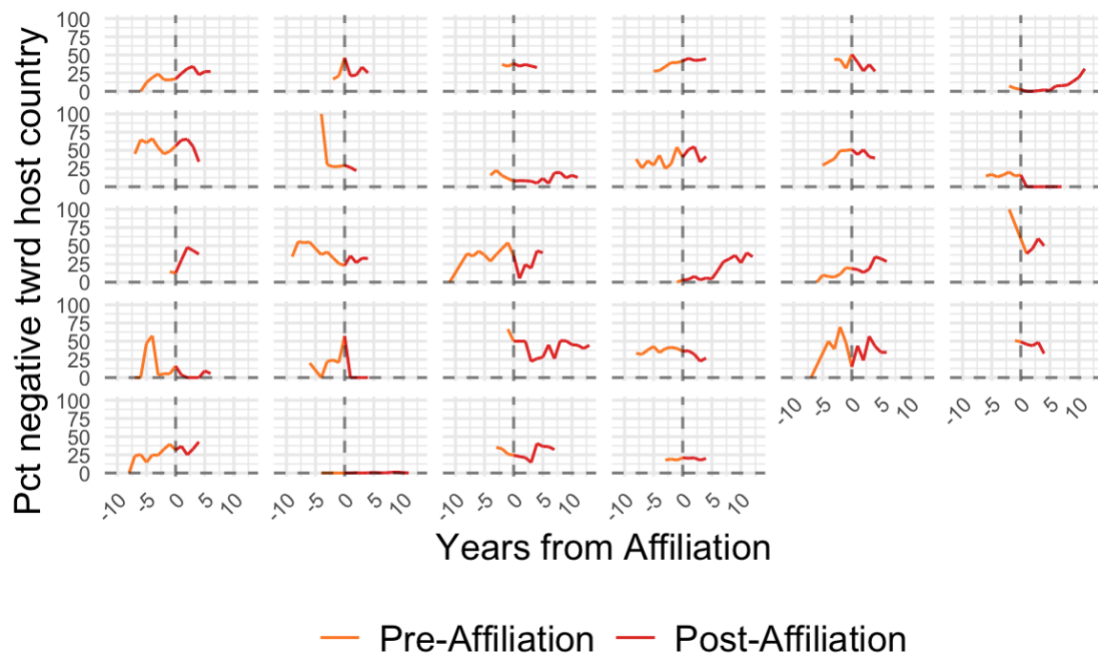


FIGURE A2. PERCENT OF NEGATIVE STORIES ABOUT A HOST COUNTRY, PRE/POST NEWS OUTLET AFFILIATION.

### A3.3. Webpage linkages

To validate our measure of media patronage, we assess the frequency that diaspora news organization websites redirect through hyperlinks to websites on the Chinese mainland, following approaches in communication and social computing for assessing interconnectedness (Freelon 2014). We extracted all URLs from all news organization website homepages and, after cleaning them and expanding shortened URLs, identified their country domain by cross-referencing the ICANN database, the website’s domain suffix (e.g. “.cn”), and using a database of website registrations from DomainTools, to look up the website’s country of registration (see Appendix A1.3). After averaging the percentage of links to China in each outlet in each year, we then compute a 3-year rolling average across all outlets with homepages available in that year to assess the average percentage of news organization homepages links that direct visitors back to the Chinese mainland.

This analysis confirms our measure of PRC linkage. Figure A3 shows that over the past twenty-three years homepage linkages to China more than tripled, from 6.8% in 2000 to 22.3% in 2023, indicating a growing share of global Chinese-language news linking to content hosted in mainland China.

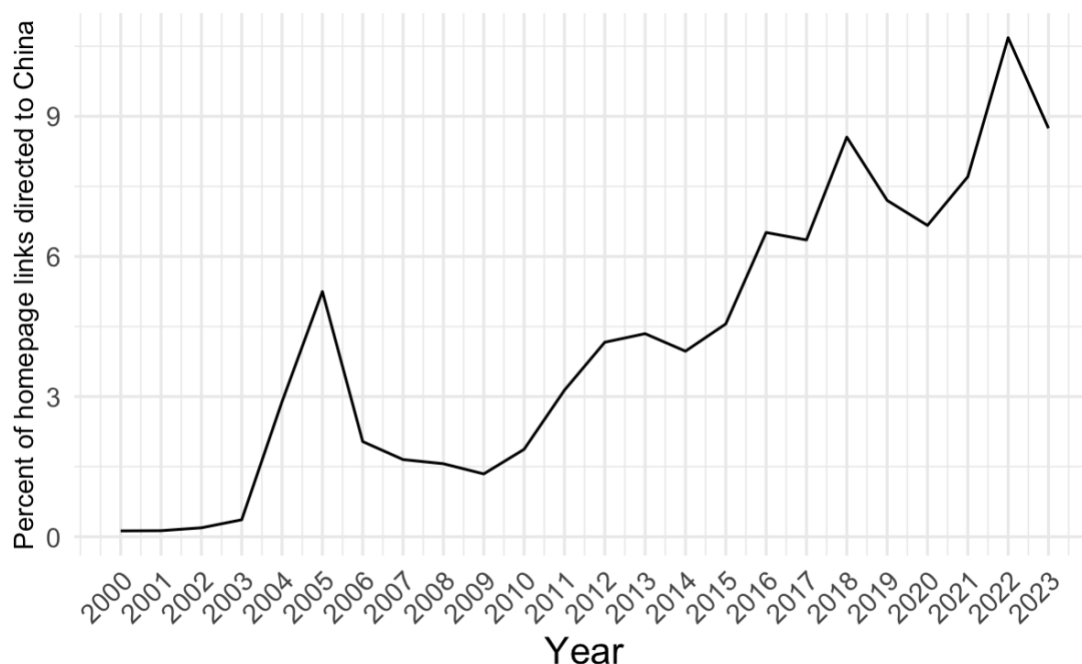


FIGURE A3. AVERAGE PERCENTAGE OF HOMEPAGE URLS LINKING TO WEBSITES REGISTERED IN CHINA.

### A3.4. Unaffiliated over time

To assess within-outlet changes in positivity among unaffiliated outlets over time, we estimate a linear regression of the percentage of positive China coverage on year, with outlet fixed effects. The specification is given by Equation A1. The outlet fixed effects absorb time-invariant differences across media outlets. The coefficient on *Year* therefore captures the average within-outlet change in positive coverage associated with a one-year increase in time.

$$\text{PctPos}_{it} = \alpha_i + \beta \text{Year}_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (\text{A1})$$

Table A5 shows, that conditional on outlet, the average decline in percent of positive stories each year is  $-0.255$  ( $\text{SE} = 0.129$ ,  $p = 0.049$ ), indicating a slightly and weakly significant association between the passage of time and outlet coverage of China.

TABLE A5. CHANGE IN POSITIVE CHINA COVERAGE OVER TIME

|                      | <i>Positive Coverage</i> |
|----------------------|--------------------------|
| Year                 | $-0.255^*$<br>(0.129)    |
| Observations         | 581                      |
| Outlet fixed effects | Yes                      |
| $R^2$                | 0.789                    |
| Adjusted $R^2$       | 0.758                    |

Standard errors in parentheses.

\* $p < 0.05$ , \*\* $p < 0.01$ , \*\*\* $p < 0.001$ .